EXPERT ASSESSMENTS

BELARUS CHANGE TRACKER

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WHAT IS THE BELARUS CHANGE TRACKER

Belarus is going through the most turbulent period since its independence. The war in Ukraine[1] and the Belarusian authorities' complicity in Russia's aggression, combined with the country's still unresolved internal political crisis of 2020, have created a "perfect storm". Features of the turbulent situation include ongoing widescale repressions, unprecedented foreign sanctions and the severance of economic relations with Western partners, international isolation and intensified social polarisation within the country. The situation poses many new challenges for researchers. It is increasingly difficult to identify sustainable and relatively long-term trends through the mists of a controlled information environment and the extreme volatility in economics, politics and public sentiment, as well as in regional security issues.

To address these challenges, our five Belarusian experts produce a quarterly analytical report, the Belarus Change Tracker. The idea behind this product is to record and analyse more general trends in place of observers' usual focus on individual events and the noise of daily information. The team includes two political analysts, two sociologists, politologist and economist. They are Pavel Slunkin, visiting fellow at the European Council on Foreign Relations; Artyom Shraibman, founder of the Sense Analytics consultancy; Alesia Rudnik, Director of the Center for New Ideas; Philipp Bikanau, independent sociologist; Henadz Korshunau, programme director of Belaruskaya Akademia and senior analyst at the Center for New Ideas; Lev Lvovskiy, academic director at BEROC

The analytical "zest" of our report is an exclusive quarterly opinion poll that enables us to record shifts in public opinion across different segments of Belarusian society[2]. The authors would like to thank Press Club Belarus for contributing to the dissemination of its results.

[1] While the authors use various designations of the RussianUkrainian war, they are all unanimous in interpreting this conflict as Russia's war against Ukraine.

[2] See Technical Annex 2 for a detailed description of the sampling and data collection method.

SUMMARY

The winter election campaign and the formation and work of the ABPA (All-Belarusian People's Assembly) have strengthened the trend towards sealing and preserving the regime and abandoning even controlled experiments with the redistribution of political influence within the system. The meeting of the All-Belarusian People's Assembly also became the climax of the gradual normalisation of Alyaksandr Lukashenka's personality cult. The process of militarisation continued in every aspect, from education to personnel policy. The growth of the infrastructure of influence of one of the highest security officials, Mikalai Karpiankou, not typical for the Belarusian regime, stands out within this trend. Within the democratic forces, the election to the Coordination Council institutionalised the structures with an alternative view on the priorities and objectives of the opposition compared to the ones of Sviatlana Tsikhanouskaya's office.

For the first time in two years, a trend towards the decrease in the Russian military presence has been observed. Belarusian diplomacy expands the geography of Alyaksandr Lukashenka's international contacts, reducing the distance from Sviatlana Tsikhanouskaya. With the crisis in relations with the West still ongoing, the integration track with Russia brings Belarusian norms closer to Russian ones, dissolving existing legal, regulatory and social differences between the countries. The democratic forces have transformed the public positioning of their international activities: advocacy for the preservation of communication channels with the Belarusian society has become a priority, replacing the previously dominant lobbying of sanctions.

In the reporting period, the Belarusian economy completed the recovery growth and proceeded with taking new heights. However, positive quantitative indicators may conceal a deterioration in the quality and sustainability of growth. The government continued to increasingly interfere in the economy, sometimes creating additional points of potential crises with its own hands.

In the reporting period, Belarus has not been able to find new trading partners. Despite the growing economic integration with Russia, Belarus remained dissatisfied with the degree of support from it. At the same time, relatively low sanctions activity can be deceptive.

The polarisation of opinions on digital platforms keeps increasing. While the Belarusian democratic forces are actively supporting Ukraine and calling for increased pressure on the Alyaksandr Lukashenka regime, the pro-government segment relies on promoting its narratives on TikTok. In the reporting period, pro-government speakers intensified the ideological component and political support for Russia in their narrative. At the same time, the main narratives of pro-democratic speakers remain the same: nostalgia for the 2020 protests and discrediting of the regime's domestic political actions. If earlier pro-democratic speakers were cautious about promoting the idea of the European future for Belarus, in spring this message became more popular on online platforms.

Public opinion remains politically polarised: the shares of supporters and opponents of the current government remain unchanged, and the extreme segments still have a very negative attitude towards each other. At the same time, general satisfaction with the socio-economic situation in the country is growing, which may affect the balance of political views in the future. Belarusians are also actively assimilating the main strategic narratives of pro-government propaganda: the only exception is ardent opponents of the regime who support the ideas promoted by pro-democratic speakers. The war continues to simultaneously divide and unite Belarusians: supporters of the regime sympathise with Russia, while opponents support Ukraine; however, both oppose the involvement of Belarus in military operations. At the same time, doubt about Ukraine's victory has significantly increased over the analysed period.

Repressions remain one of the most important tools in the relations between the state and society. In the reporting period, they were concentrated on destroying the solidarity infrastructure and fighting the Belarusian diaspora. Besides the repressive pressure on society, the regime of Alyaksandr

Lukashenka continues to attack Belarusian culture and identity, systematically supporting "the Russian world". Society can resist only in a form of an anonymous partisan movement, and this trend is gradually spreading to the Belarusian diaspora.

1 FOREIGN POLICY

For the first time in two years, a trend towards the decrease in the Russian military presence has been observed. Belarusian diplomacy expands the geography of Alyaksandr Lukashenka's international contacts, reducing the distance from Sviatlana Tsikhanouskaya. With the crisis in relations with the West still ongoing, the integration track with Russia brings Belarusian norms closer to Russian ones, dissolving existing legal, regulatory and social differences between the countries. The democratic forces have transformed the public positioning of their international activities: advocacy for the preservation of communication channels with the Belarusian society has become a priority, replacing the previously dominant lobbying of sanctions.

DECREASE IN THE RUSSIAN MILITARY PRESENCE

For the first time in two years, analysts of the Belarus Change Tracker have observed not an expansion, but a reduction in the Russian military presence in Belarus as there were no noteworthy events that would have made Minsk more militarily and politically dependent on Moscow during the reporting period. Although the so far last group of Russian mobilised soldiers who were trained in Belarus was withdrawn back in July 2023, and the Russian aviation, which was part of the regional group of troops, withdrew in August 2023, at that time the trend towards the decrease in the Russian presence could not be confirmed due to the subsequent deployment of several thousands of the Wagner Group mercenaries.

After the death of the Wagner Group's head Yevgeny Prigozhin and the liquidation of his private military company, the number of mercenaries in Belarus decreased to a minimum. Some of them signed contracts with the law enforcement agencies of Belarus and provide training to Belarusian soldiers and officers. According to the estimates of the Belarusian Hajun [1], the total number of Wagner mercenaries in Belarus does not exceed several hundreds, and the estimated number of Russian military personnel is about 2,000 people. Although this number slightly exceeds the quantitative indicators of the permanent presence of Russian military personnel as of the end of 2021, it does not pose an immediate threat to the Lukashenka regime.

At the same time, the practice of conducting permanent exercises, training sessions, training of regular reservists and operational readiness inspections, including joint ones with Russia, still remains. In the reporting period, the largest of them were exercises for the case of use of non-strategic nuclear weapons, which took place in the territory of both countries. Remarkably, the Russian Foreign Ministry insists that during the exercises "there was no violation of the Treaty on the Non-Proliferation of Nuclear Weapons"[2]. which may indicate that the Belarusian side did not receive direct access to nuclear weapons, despite Lukashenka's regular opposite bravado. The only thing that does not follow the trend is the number of Russian military aircraft in Belarus, which increased by several units in the spring of 2024 compared to the beginning of the year.

RETURN OF LUKASHENKA TO THE INTERNATIONAL ARENA

Belarusian diplomacy is consistently working to expand the geography of Alyaksandr Lukashenka's international contacts, which has been undermined by a series of crises since 2020 and especially by

[1] New batch of Mi-35M, movements of air defense units, adoption of the new National Security Concept and Military Doctrine: review of military events in Belarus in April / Belarusian Hajun Project, may 2024

[2] Рябков заявил, что ядерные учения РФ и Белоруссии не нарушают ДНЯО / ТАСС, май 2024

the participation of his regime in the war against Ukraine. Since the beginning of 2024, Lukashenka has made state, official and working visits to Russia, Uzbekistan, Mongolia and Azerbaijan. In total, after the 2020 election, Lukashenka had meetings at the highest (president or prime minister) and high (ministerial) levels with representatives of at least 28 states. And although a fairly large number of them took place during his participation in the World Climate Summit in the UAE, where he held short meetings with 13 foreign leaders[3], his distance from Sviatlana Tsikhanouskaya, which was huge in 2021[4], is gradually closing.

The practice of unprecedentedly frequent meetings and telephone conversations between Lukashenka and Putin, established after August 2020, also persists. Since the beginning of the year, Lukashenka has visited Russia twice with working visits, and Putin has visited Belarus once on an official visit; they have had five telephone conversations.

INTEGRATION INTO RUSSIA

The frequency of contacts with the Russian leadership correlates with how fast Belarus switches to Russian-centric tracks in legislation, education and social affairs. Belarus and Russia have approved the main directions of integration and the program of coordinated actions in foreign policy for 2024-2026[5]. The integration directions contain 11 sections, including macroeconomic, tax and customs policy, financial market, trade, operation of the common energy markets and nuclear energy. The document also contains a section on humanitarian cooperation, including the creation of a common information space. Although there have been no radical changes on the integration track, the process itself is gradually bringing Belarusian norms closer to Russian ones, dissolving existing legal, regulatory and social differences between the countries.

For example, in the reporting period, the parties announced the unification of the lists of “extremists” and “extremist resources,” which will significantly increase the threat to hundreds or even thousands of Belarusian citizens who moved to Russia after the crackdown on protests in 2020. Russian Ambassador to Belarus Boris Gryzlov also announced the intentions of the two countries to create "common history textbooks for schools and universities."

The military doctrine of Belarus has already been changed in a similar pro-Russian spirit, acquiring an openly anti-Western and ideologically coloured character[6]. The document accuses Western countries of seeking to take control of "the resources of the entire planet", NATO is called "a tool of expansion", and Poland and the Baltic states are accused of trying to change the constitutional system of Belarus. The updated version of the military doctrine allows the participation of the Belarusian army in armed conflicts outside the territory of Belarus, secures the deployment of Russian nuclear weapons, and allows the use of military force in peacetime inside the country.

DEADLOCK IN RELATIONS WITH THE WEST, AGGRAVATION OF RELATIONS WITH ARMENIA

Belarus and Western countries maintain the status quo in their relations, or rather a deadlock reached in 2022. The European Union and the United States are not ready to make concessions to the Minsk regime in order to improve relations with it. At the same time, they are being extremely cautious,

[3] Участие во Всемирном саммите по борьбе с изменением климата / Президент Республики Беларусь, декабрь 2023

[4] В одной картинке. С кем встречались Лукашенко и Тихановская после выборов / Зеркало, июль 2021

[5] ВГС утвердил Основные направления реализации положений Договора о создании Союзного государства на 2024–2026 годы / Национальный правовой Интернет-портал Республики Беларусь, январь 2024

[6] Решение Всебелорусского Народного Собрания «Об утверждении Военной доктрины Республики Беларусь» / Национальный правовой Интернет-портал Республики Беларусь, апрель 2024

fearing to provoke an even greater aggravation of the military-political situation in the region that may result from destructive actions of the Lukashenka regime. In fact, Western countries have recognised the lack of new resources and levers, which could change the behaviour of the Belarusian authorities in the current regional situation. This consolidates the current state of affairs, leaving the country to be a zone of exclusive political, military, economic and information dominance of Russia.

On the other hand, Lukashenka also does not demonstrate a willingness to take even small steps towards the expectations of Western politicians, which would allow him to stop the slow degradation of Belarus's sovereignty and at least partially restore the Western vector of foreign policy. As long as the economic situation in Belarus remains stable and Lukashenka's relations with Russia do not cause concern, the regime in Minsk will probably not be interested in any significant initiative concessions to the West without some particularly large 'advance payment' by the other side. The deep problems in the relations are combined with an unprecedented crisis of trust between the parties, which is only getting worse over time.

In late 2023 – early 2024, some steps of the Belarusian authorities were indicative of their attempts to test the new Polish government for a possible softening of their line in terms of Belarus. The controlled migrant assaults on the Polish border almost stopped[7], the rhetoric became more peaceful[8], Lukashenka publicly spoke about secret contacts with Poland concerning the release of political prisoners[9]. However, it quickly became clear that the differences between the governments were so great that there would be no rapprochement after all. In April 2024, there were 60 times more attempts to illegally cross the Polish border from the Belarusian side than in January[10], and the attacks on Polish border guards became more aggressive, resulting in several soldiers being admitted to hospital after they were stabbed or injured with a stone[11]. As a result, Poland decided to restore a more than 200 meters wide buffer zone, prohibiting access to a number of areas in the border zone with Belarus[12].

After Minsk and Moscow did not support their CSTO ally in the Azerbaijani-Armenian war, in fact taking the side of Azerbaijan, their relations with Armenia have also become increasingly tense. Yerevan defiantly "froze its participation in the CSTO" and accused "two CSTO countries of preparing for the war" of Azerbaijan and Armenia in 2020[13]. Armenia rekindled its relations with the democratic forces of Belarus: Prime Minister Pashinyan[14] and Speaker of Parliament Simonyan held meetings with Tsikhanouskaya[15], and the Armenian authorities granted political asylum to a Belarusian citizen detained in Armenia at the request of the Belarusian security services[16]. Lukashenka, in turn, during his visit to Azerbaijan in May this year, went to the territories of Nagorno-Karabakh brought under Azerbaijan's control as a result of the war in 2023, and offered "assistance in the post-war reconstruction of the territories."[17]

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[7] Коршунов, Г. Беларусские границы: абсолютный штиль в тени железного занавеса / Центр новых идей, февраль 2024

[8] Поздравление народу Польши с Национальным праздником независимости / Президент Республики Беларусь, ноябрь 2023

[9] Лукашенко об освобождении политзаключенных: «Должны быть определенные условия» / Reformation, ноябрь 2023

[10] Коршунов, Г. Ситуация на границах: будет жарко / Центр новых идей, май 2024

[11] Мигрант ранил ножом польского солдата на границе с Беларусью / Reformation, май 2024

[12] Projekt rozporządzenia Ministra Spraw Wewnętrznych i Administracji w sprawie wprowadzenia czasowego zakazu przebywania na określonym obszarze w strefie nadgranicznej przyległej do granicy państwowej z Republiką Białorusi / Biuletyn informacji publicznej Rządowego Centrum legislacji, июнь 2024

[13] Пашинян обвинил две страны ОДКБ в оказании помощи Азербайджану в 2020 году / ТАСС, май 2024

[14] Тихановская в Гранаде поговорила с Николом Пашиняном / Наша Ніва, октябрь 2023

[15] Ален Симонян и Светлана Тихановская обсудили вопрос предоставления политубежища гражданину Беларуси в Армении / Factor, март 2024

[16] Задержанный в Армении по запросу силовиков беларус Ярослав Новиков получит убежище в этой стране / Белсат, март 2024

[17] Лукашенко предложил Алиеву «возрождать» Карабах, откуда в прошлом году от войны бежали армяне / Белсат, май 2024

NEW PARTNERS OF THE DEMOCRATIC FORCES AND NEW PRIORITIES IN THE NARRATIVE

Sviatlana Tsikhanouskaya continues to expand the geography of international allies of the Belarusian democratic forces, among other ways, by establishing cooperation with influential international organisations and informal international clubs. For the first time, she met with NATO Secretary General Jens Stoltenberg; she also held a briefing for permanent representatives of all NATO member countries[18]. Tsikhanouskaya's team emphasizes that the dialogue with NATO lies exclusively in the political dimension and does not concern military security. For the first time, Tsikhanouskaya attended the G7 minister's meeting as a special guest[19], and once again made a report to the UN Human Rights Council.

As part of the formalisation of relations between the democratic forces and international partners, an agreement on cooperation between the European Parliament and the Belarusian democratic forces was signed in May. This is the first time the European Parliament has signed a document of this kind with an institution that is not an official government[20].

Responding to the criticism from its partners in the democratic circles, Tsikhanouskaya's office noticeably redistributed narrative priorities in the public positioning of its international activities. Although the general standing of the Office remains the same, the amount of attention paid to specific areas of its work by the media has changed. The previously very popular topic of lobbying for sanctions at the meetings with foreign leaders has now given way to advocating for maintaining channels of communication with the Belarusian society, issuing visas and promoting mobility, as well as preventing the isolation of Belarusians.

[18] Светлана Тихановская впервые встретилась с генеральным секретарем НАТО / Святлана Ціханоўская, май 2024

[19] Встреча министров G7, визит в Канаду, президентство в Бюро Совета Европы по молодежи. Итоги работы Офиса Светланы Тихановской 15-21 апреля 2024 / Святлана Ціханоўская, апрель 2024

[20] Роберта Метсола и Светлана Тихановская подписали договор о сотрудничестве между Европарламентом и демократическими силами Беларуси / Святлана Ціханоўская, май 2024

2 DOMESTIC POLITICS

The winter election campaign and the formation and work of the ABPA (All-Belarusian People's Assembly) have strengthened the trend towards sealing and preserving the regime and abandoning even controlled experiments with the redistribution of political influence within the system. The meeting of the All-Belarusian People's Assembly also became the climax of the gradual normalisation of Alyaksandr Lukashenka's personality cult. The process of militarisation continued in every aspect, from education to personnel policy. The growth of the infrastructure of influence of one of the highest security officials, Mikalai Karpiankou, not typical for the Belarusian regime, stands out within this trend. Within the democratic forces, the election to the Coordination Council institutionalised the structures with an alternative view on the priorities and objectives of the opposition compared to the ones of Sviatlana Tsikhanouskaya's office.

SEALING AND PRESERVING THE REGIME

Further drift of the Belarusian regime towards sealing and abandoning even the facade attributes of electoral democracy and pluralism was the main domestic political trend of the reporting period. The Soviet-style choreography of domestic political procedures leaves no room for surprises. This was most clearly manifested during the two main political events of the winter-spring of 2024 – the single voting day for electing the parliament and local councils and the first meeting of the All-Belarusian People's Assembly (ABPA) as a body with constitutional powers.

At all its stages, the electoral procedure was devoid of even those imitation elements of competition that were common to Belarusian elections until the 2020s. The government began this campaign after having 'cleansed' the political parties, with only four pro-government ones remained (Belaya Rus', Liberal Democratic Party of Belarus, Republican Party of Labour and Justice and the Communist Party of Belarus). Alternative candidates for parliament not only were unable to register as candidates, but, according to the available data, none of them were allowed to create even an initiative group to collect signatures. The only opposition leader who publicly declared his desire to take part in the election, Dzmitry Kuchuk, was arrested shortly after the campaign under criminal charges. As expected, at all levels of the election commissions, all members were under the government's control. People who had been active during the previous election campaigns as observers were subject to searches and detentions right before the February 2024 election. For the first time, Minsk deliberately did not invite the OSCE and other European structures to observe the election.

In March and April, the Council of the Republic was formed in a similarly controlled manner to consist entirely of loyalists, and then in the same manner the All-Belarusian People's Assembly was formed. Its chairman (Alyaksandr Lukashenka) and deputy chairman (Alyaksandr Kosints), as well as the executive organ of the organisation, were elected on an uncontested basis with only a few delegates (out of more than 1,160) voting against these decisions. The meeting of the All-Belarusian People's Assembly on 24-25 April was held according to a well-planned scenario. The people called to the microphone made prepared speeches and were pre-selected to clearly reflect different groups of society: farmers, industry, "civil society" loyal to the authorities, members of parliament, etc. In other words, the format of the event was as close as possible to the Soviet and Chinese manner of holding congresses of the ruling party and other supreme collective bodies.

Judging by the protective rhetoric of Lukashenka and his subordinates at the ABPA, this institution is not supposed to become the engine of even a controlled transformation of the system in the near future. The members of the Presidium of the ABPA fit into the same conservative model: only two of the 13 members of the Presidium (excluding Lukashenka and Kosinets) can be considered top

officials – the governors of the Hrodna and Brest oblasts, Uladzimir Karanik and Yury Shuleika. The rest of the bureaucrats in the Presidium are little known and represent either the middle level of the political establishment or the pro-government "civil society" and the public sector of the economy[1].

The trend towards the preservation of the regime was also manifested in the qualitatively growing influence of the pro-government parties, including Belaya Rus', which had ambitions to be the regime's party. It did not win a majority in the House of Representatives, taking only 51 of the 110 seats. On the whole, the parties did not increase their role in the electoral process: among all the registered candidates for parliament, the share of party nominees fell to 40% (from more than 50% in 2019), and party representatives in local election commissions accounted for 8.3% (a slight increase from 6.5% in 2019). Thus, Lukashenka refuses to give new political weight even to the pro-government institutions like the All-Belarusian People's Assembly or the "regime's party" with its three satellites.

MILITARISATION

The militarisation of various segments of domestic politics, including personnel policy, has been going on for several years. The reporting period was no exception.

The powers of law enforcement agencies have been extended again. In particular, amendments to the "anti-terrorist" legislation came into force on 1 January[2]. The KGB was given the authority to use firearms in a crowd, even when passers-by might be injured, as well as to shoot in the direction of explosive storage facilities. In addition, the KGB became the body that coordinates anti-terrorist activities of all other government agencies and organisations. It also became possible to involve cash collection services in the fight against terrorism. In February, Lukashenka changed the provisions of the general military regulations, giving the military more rights to use force against civilians, eliminating some preventive measures for the arbitrary use of force (including warning shots) and exonerating the military personnel from responsibility for using force in excess of authority[3].

The logic of militarisation was in the preparations for the election campaign. A few weeks before the election, law enforcement and civilian officials began to regularly mention the threat of terrorist attacks on voting days. On the eve of the single voting day, the Ministry of Internal Affairs staged exercises of detention by force at polling stations, and Lukashenka instructed to arm police patrols with firearms[4].

After involving civilians in law enforcement within the "people's militia" initiative in 2023, the government took a step further and in April 2024 launched a training program for snipers from among the members of the Belarusian Society of Hunters and Fishermen headed by former Interior Minister Ihar Shunevich[5]. In April, the head of the Ministry for Emergency Situations (who previously worked in the Ministry of Internal Affairs) Vadzim Sinyausky reported that the ministry had successfully completed arming the personnel of the Ministry for Emergency Situations with small arms and was planning a new arming program for the future.

Many civilian positions continued to be filled by former law enforcement personnel. After the election campaign, the number of deputies of the House of Representatives who previously worked in law

[1] Лукашенко стал председателем Всебелорусского народного собрания / Позірк, апрель 2024

[2] Сотрудникам КГБ разрешат стрелять в толпе. Власти опубликовали принятые поправки в законы о борьбе с терроризмом / Зеркало, декабрь 2023

[3] Права человека в Беларуси: основные тренды государственной политики / Беларусский Хельсинкский Комитет, май 2024

[4] «Людзі павінны адчуваць сябе ў бяспецы ў любы час сутак». Лукашэнка ўпэўнены, што такое адчуванне з'яўляецца пры назіранні ўзброеных сілавікоў / Наша Ніва, февраль 2024

[5] Шуневич рассказал, что в Беларуси охотников переучивают на снайперов / Зеркало, апрель 2024

enforcement agencies increased by five (from 18 to 23)[6]. In March, deputy head of Lukashenka's Security Service Mikalai Shkred was appointed First Deputy Head of the Belarus President Property Management Directorate. In April, former First Deputy Head of the Academy of the Ministry of Internal Affairs Aliaksei Bashan became a member and then Deputy Chairman of the Central Election Committee. Ihar Burmistrau, former First Deputy Commander of the Internal Troops, was appointed head of Navapolatsk. Former KGB colonel Uladzimir Kozyr became the head of the MTS mobile operator company. In May, former head of the engineer troops Andrei Kurakou became director of the Belarusian State Archive of Scientific and Technical Documents.

Militarisation is also manifested in more active mobilisation and conscription actions the authorities are taking against civilians. In February, rectors of Belarusian universities were summoned to a shooting drill. In April, Lukashenka signed a law that made conscription procedure easier (in case of mobilisation, conscription notices can be sent by mobile text messages) and increased penalties for evading military service and training. Also, it will now be possible to recruit people under investigation, those with outstanding convictions and prisoners from penal facilities to serve under contract[7]. In April, 6,500 people were called up from the reserve for several weeks as part of the largest operational readiness inspection in recent years[8].

Militarisation of education also continues. In March, one of the leading secondary educational institutions in the country, the BSU Lyceum, was named after the founder of the Soviet secret services Feliks Dzerzhynsky, and in April, the Dzerzhynets military-patriotic club was founded in the lyceum and started taking students to firing ranges to practice shooting and other military skills. Kulyashou Mahilou State University decided to open the first in the country Military-Patriotic Education program.

Within the militarisation trend, there is a remarkable independent subtrend – the ongoing growth of influence of the Deputy Head of the Ministry of Internal Affairs, Commander of the Internal Troops Mikalai Karpiankou, which is abnormal for the Belarusian law enforcement system. During the reporting period, Karpiankou continued to set up regional special forces units of the Internal Troops aimed at combating "extremism". In April, the 12th unit "Thunder" was founded in Mahilou, and in May, the 13th unit "Vityaz" was created in Vitsyebsk. Members of these units are systematically involved in detaining opponents of the government. During the reporting period, these and the previously created special forces units of the Internal Troops regularly participated in joint training with the Wagner Group mercenaries remaining in Belarus, and Karpiankou became the public face of this cooperation. His presence in the media concerning this topic became so intense that it attracted the attention of Lukashenka, who in February expressed a hint of criticism towards Karpiankou's "excessive praise of the Russian PMC[9]." The subsequent slowdown in the coverage of Karpiankou's activity in the state media, however, did not stop the general of the Interior Affairs Ministry: in May, he announced the creation of a charitable foundation "Molodaya Gvardiya" (Young Guard) that would raise funds from businesses for the work of 18 military-patriotic clubs established under the auspices of the Internal Troops throughout the country[10].

This is the first case when Karpiankou's unprecedented activity has gone beyond the governmental system, an attempt to develop his influence infrastructure through horizontal communication with business. The fund also opens more opportunities for attracting foreign (primarily Russian) funding for this clearly pro–Russian security official and his structures.

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[6] Как думаете, много ли экс-силовиков работает во власти? Мы подробно их всех подсчитали — и вот что выяснили / Зеркало, апрель 2024

[7] Лукашенко подписал закон об СМС-повестках, ужесточении наказания для уклонистов и службе в армии для судимых / Зеркало, апрель 2024

[8] После окончания проверки боевой готовности военнообязанные возвращаются домой / Motolko.help, апрель 2024

[9] «Ах, Вагнер, ах, Вагнер». Лукашенко упрекнул министра и офицеров, которые по телевизору восхваляли российских наемников / Зеркало, февраль 2024

[10] У Карпенкова появилась своя «Молодая гвардия» — фонд, куда будут привлекать деньги для военно-патриотических клубов / Зеркало, май 2024

DEEPENING OF THE PERSONALITY CULT

As Lukashenka approaches the 30th anniversary of ruling the country, his regime began first to allow, and then to encourage more open manifestations of the cult of the autocrat's personality. This process was initiated by the radicalisation of propaganda after 2020 and the consolidation of a special status for Lukashenka personally in the Constitution in 2022 – the opportunity to be both the president and the head of the ABPA. For several years, Lukashenka's messianic role in the Belarusian history and his almost divine status have already been regularly highlighted by some of notorious propagandists.

However, in the reporting period, other manifestations of this emerging cult were observed. In January, the government-affiliated Archpriest of the Belarusian Orthodox Church Fyodar Povny announced that Lukashenka had the divine gift of a prophet[11]. The head of the Academy of Sciences Uladzimir Husakou said that Lukashenka could have claimed the Nobel Peace Prize, if it hadn't been so politicised. Husakou also admitted that he had initiated the publication of Lukashenka's "works", referring to his articles and interviews[12]. The idea was supported by the pro-government Writers' Union in June, after the end of the reporting period. In May, employees of Belarusbank in Krychau took part in the marching and singing competition with a song that contains the lines "Our Father is cool, there's only one like him in the world. With the Father, our country is safe, but he doesn't have time to rest."

However, all these isolated and rather anecdotal manifestations of the personality cult couldn't compete with the number of speeches praising Lukashenka on the first day of the meeting of the All-Belarusian People's Assembly on 24 April. Since one of the items on the agenda was the election of Lukashenka as the chairman of the ABPA, the participants were required to explain their choice in prepared speeches. As a result, the speeches turned into a group session of persuading the leader to take responsibility for another major position in the country and explaining to the participants (and the TV audience) why Lukashenka was an indispensable leader. This procedure was not much different from similar bureaucratic rituals performed in the USSR, China and the personalist dictatorships of Central Asia.

ELECTORAL INSTITUTIONALISATION OF THE DEMOCRATIC FORCES OPPOSING TSIKHANOUSKAYA

On 25-27 May, the democratic forces conducted their first electoral campaign – election to the third convocation of the Coordination Council (CC)[13]. More than 200 candidates from 11 electoral lists competed for 80 seats (Aliaksandr Azarau's list "Law and Order" was removed from the election before the vote). The election was held under the proportional system through a special electronic platform. It resulted in the formation of the CC without a dominant force: the winner of the election, the list of Pavel Latushka and movement "For Freedom", won 35% of the votes, followed by the list of Vadzim Prakopyeu and Andrei Yahorau with 16%.

Despite the low turnout (just over 6,700 people), the very process of forming one of the main opposition bodies in exile through a competitive electoral procedure demonstrates a new quality of the development of the democratic forces. The last time when electoral mechanisms influenced the representation in the opposition was in 2020, when Sviatlana Tsikhanouskaya became the leader following the results of the presidential election in Belarus.

[11] Фёдар Поўны абвесціў Лукашэнку прарокам, а сабе прыпісаў звышчалавечыя здольнасці / Наша Ніва, январь 2024

[12] Кіраўнік Акадэміі навук заявіў, што Лукашэнка мог бы прэтэндаваць на Нобелеўскую прэмію / Наша Ніва, январь 2024

[13] Выбары ў Каардынацыйную раду III склікання / Каардынацыйная рада, апрель 2024

Moreover, the election to the CC made it possible to institutionalise a significant part of the structures with their own vision of the mission and strategy of the democratic forces different from the one offered by the Office of Sviatlana Tsikhanouskaya (OST) and the United Transitional Cabinet (UTC). So far, there is no open opposition to Tsikhanouskaya's structures or refusal to recognise her leadership. Still, most of the lists that made it to the CC offer different options for modifying the priorities of the democratic forces: from lobbying for stronger international pressure on the regime and uniting the diaspora into a single large movement to focusing on mobility, visa problems experienced by Belarusians and negotiations with Minsk for the release of political prisoners. The European Choice list close to the OST and UTC, which fully shares the agenda of the structures dominating in the democratic forces, got 9% of the votes, taking the fourth place.

3 THE DOMESTIC ECONOMY

In the reporting period, the Belarusian economy completed the recovery growth and proceeded with taking new heights. However, positive quantitative indicators may conceal a deterioration in the quality and sustainability of growth. The government continued to increasingly interfere in the economy, sometimes creating additional points of potential crises with its own hands.

AFTER OVERCOMING THE DECLINE, THE ECONOMY BREAKS ALL RECORDS AND FORECASTS

After falling by 4.4% in 2022, the economy, under the influence of the expansionist government policy and with the versatile assistance of Russia, showed a fairly high rate of recovery, gaining back 3.6 percentage points in 2023. Given the preceding long-term stagnation, most analysts expected that, having completed the recovery growth, in 2024 the Belarusian economy would return to a trajectory with an average growth rate of 1% per year. In autumn 2023, the World Bank expected the Belarusian economy to grow by 0.8% in 2024, EDB's expectation was 1%, EBRD's — 1.3%, IMF's — 1.3%, BEROC's — 1.1%.

However, the results of the first four months of 2024 made international institutions revise their forecasts several times. Compared to the corresponding months of last year, the economic growth in January amounted to 2.8%, in February to 5.3%, in March to 4.4%, and in April to as much as 7.6%, making the average growth rate for the first four months exceed 5%. A significant share of the February growth is explained by the leap year factor, so we have observed four months of consistent increase in growth rate. Taking into account the leap year factor, Q1–2024 still corresponded to a positive stagnation scenario, but the April data potentially indicate a break from this trend and, if confirmed in the next few months, will mean a qualitative change in the trajectory of the Belarusian economy.

During the period of the recovery growth completion, i.e. from January to March, industry and trade were the main drivers of the economy. Industry naturally turned out to be the main beneficiary of the expansionist government policy, the opened demand on the Russian market and the "new oil rent"[1]. The expansionist policy meant cheap loans and a directive redistribution of funds in favour of large state-owned enterprises. The phenomenon of the "new oil rent" arose when, due to the restrictions imposed on Russia, Belarus could buy Urals crude oil at a discount of 15-30 USD per barrel and then sell oil products at world prices. The growth of industry partly pushed trade, but the main factor of the growth of the sector's retail part was the fast growth of wages. While the economy in general reached the level of 2021 only at the beginning of 2024, average real wages already exceeded the level of 2021 in the autumn of 2023. This happened because the negative demographic trends, together with the mass emigration of people of working age, created a shortage in the labour market in recent years, which resulted in the increase in wages and household consumption outperforming all other rates. Another consequence of accelerated wage growth, combined with the sanctions restricting Belarusians in ways to save money, was record demand for real estate, which at the end of the reporting period created another leader in economic growth – in April, the construction sector exceeded last year's output by 21.5%, which provided 1 percentage point of the total GDP growth.

Transport and IT have been outsiders over the past few years. The physical volume of goods transported is still almost 40% behind the pre-sanctions levels. However, it seems that the decline of

[1] Подробнее можно прочитать в материалах «Возвращение нефтяной ренты» и «Возвращение нефтяной ренты. Часть 2» на сайте beroc.org

IT, which used to be a growth driver, finally ended, and the sector began to show growth in April. Since this qualitative change has so far been observed only in one month, it is necessary to wait for additional data, but it is likely that the sector will finally break out of the outsiders, albeit significantly reduced in size.

DIRIGISME CONTINUES AND INTENSIFIES

The active and increasing government intervention in the economy was the main trend of the domestic economic policy in the reporting period. 2024 started with the highest-level officials recognising the shortage of labour resources and general demographic problems in the country. According to the survey of the job portal rabota.by, 75% of employers see the shortage of labour resources as the main problem of the labour market in the country. These data are confirmed by the surveys conducted by BEROC among small and medium-sized businesses, according to which the shortage of personnel is one of the main problems faced by businesses in Belarus.

In January, the government approved the Concept of Migration Policy of Belarus for 2024-2028[2]. According to this document, the authorities plan to attract foreigners via information campaigns and work on improving the tolerance of Belarusians. The Ministry of Labour chose a liberal path and conducted a survey among trade unions in order to collect proposals for measures that can attract migrants[3]. The Ministry of Internal Affairs offered its own solution of the problem. In early February, it proposed to reintroduce punishment for "social parasitism"[4]. Finally, in April, Alyaksandr Lukashenka himself came up with an idea, proposing to bring retirees back to factories [5]. Earlier, in November 2023, the government had already increased the period of mandatory working placement of medical graduates during residency from two to five years. As this decree was being adopted, Alyaksandr Lukashenka began to publicly consider the need to introduce such mandatory placement for other graduates of Belarusian universities, regardless of their form of study. May witnessed a battle against the emigration of school graduates – the Ministry of Education stopped issuing documents confirming the legality of school certificates, which are often included in the package of documents required for university admission abroad. Also, the ban on advertising of education abroad came into force, and the status of a foreign university student would no longer provide a deferment from the draft for male students. Finally, according to information from sources in the Ministry of Education, the agency is actively discussing the possibility to stop issuing secondary education certificates to graduates altogether, which may in fact become a prohibitive barrier for Belarusians who wish to study abroad.

The administrative price control system introduced last year was considered a success despite the fact that, according to Belstat, the average profit of enterprises in 2023 decreased by 8.1% while the revenue grew by 12%. In 2024, the trends naturally persisted: despite the growth of labour and logistics costs, a significant part of companies cannot adequately increase selling prices. As a result, the share of unprofitable companies in January-February 2024 amounted to 19%. Compared to the same period last year, the share increased just slightly, but the amount of losses of companies increased by 77%. In Q1–2024, despite the overall impressive economic growth, the average profit of enterprises fell by another 12% compared to the same period last year. In addition, the theory that real problems of enterprises are much more serious than it looks appears to be increasingly solid. Unable to compensate for costs, enterprises begin to spend their circulating capital. The share of

[2] Постановление Совета Министров Республики Беларусь от 23 января 2024 г. № 48 «Об утверждении Концепции миграционной политики Республики Беларусь на 2024–2028 годы» / Национальный правовой Интернет-портал Республики Беларусь, январь 2024.

[3] В Минтруда обеспокоились дефицитом работников и бросились закрывать кадровые «дыры» экспатами — нанимателям разослали письма из-за проблемы / Зеркало, январь 2024

[4] Граждане алкоголики и хулиганы, кто хочет поработать? МВД предлагают вернуть статью против тунеядцев / Белорусы и рынок, февраль 2024

[5] Лукашенко предложил закрывать кадровые дыры пенсионерами / Наша Ніва, апрель 2024

enterprises that do not have their own circulating capital increased by 25% over the year and amounted to more than 30% of the total number of companies[6].

Despite this, in May, the Ministry of Antimonopoly Regulation and Trade confirmed its intentions to continue regulating prices until the "negative external factors" disappear. One can only guess what factors they meant, since the price shock following the reorientation of logistics chains because of the sanctions should have ended a year ago, and the main pro-inflationary factors at the moment are internal: the increase in labour costs and a corresponding increase in domestic demand caused by the increase in wages.

In the reporting period, the government continued its earlier attack on private businesses. The update of the law on entrepreneurial activity is coming to its final stage. It is still unknown which types of activities will be banned for self-employed and individual entrepreneurs, and the ban will already come into force on 1 October 2024.

In February, Prime Minister Halouchanka said that Belarusian businesses had too many privileges while the state budget needed money. The official called to cancel all tax breaks as soon as possible. The Minister of Health started checking the remaining private medical centres in the country, claiming that they charge customers "unfairly high prices." Prime Minister Halouchanka also called for the control of prices in private dental offices. Transport Minister Hladki joined the marathon for budget support with the idea of confiscating the transport of illegal carriers in favour of the budget. The Ministry of Taxes and Duties announced an audit of bloggers and influencers and also decided to address the issue of taxing tips. Since 1 March, Belarusian security forces have received legal round-the-clock access to all personal transactions of funds in the country, as well as the ability to block any transfer for 10 days without any explanation.

In March, Lukashenka turned his attention to the National Bank and suggested that the interests of this institution did not always align with the interests of the state. As a result, the State Control Committee was instructed to take formal control of the Central Bank operation. In April, Lukashenka announced that it was necessary to reform the banking sector, i.e. reduce the number of commercial banks.

When facing crises, sanctions and general uncertainty, the natural instinct of governments is always to introduce manual control, including in the economy. In developed countries, this instinct leads governments to discretionary policy limited by existing institutions and a system of checks and balances. The Belarusian authorities are not at all bound by such restrictions, so any ideas can be immediately implemented, making the situation even less predictable for market participants and thus generally more fragile. Despite this, the authorities will likely continue following this course of action until it results in a crisis of their own making. The quantitative successes of the last year only make the officials pay even less attention to the degradation of qualitative indicators.

[6] Кажется, в экономике Беларуси надувается кредитный пузырь / Белорусы и рынок, июнь 2024

4 FOREIGN ECONOMIC RELATIONS

In the reporting period, Belarus has not been able to find new trading partners. Despite the growing economic integration with Russia, Belarus remained dissatisfied with the degree of support from it. At the same time, relatively low sanctions activity can be deceptive.

DISSATISFACTION WITH RUSSIA GROWS FASTER THAN TRADE TURNOVER

In January-May 2024, Russia continued to be Belarus's main trading partner. Its share in the trade turnover of Belarus has dropped from the highs reached at the beginning of the war to 60%. Nevertheless, Minsk keeps almost all of its growth prospects connected to the Russian market, Russian capital and Russian logistics.

Unlike in the previous periods, when Belarus was Russia's net recipient in economic terms, the attacks of the Armed Forces of Ukraine in the reporting period resulted in Russia sometimes requiring Belarusian assistance.

After a series of attacks in the territory of the Belgorod oblast, Russia began to experience the shortage of chicken eggs and poultry meat. This happened because up to 10% of all Russian eggs were produced in the Belgorod oblast. Vladimir Putin had to personally comment on the sharp rise in prices for basic food products. As a result, the situation on the Russian market was smoothed over thanks to a twofold increase in exports from Belarus.

Later, the new AFU drones turned out to be capable of reaching and hitting almost all oil refineries located in central Russia. Such attacks have had an unusual military and economic effect. On the one hand, the volume of oil supplied by Russia to the world market has not decreased, and on the other, due to Russia's poor logistics, a local shortage of oil products began to grow in the central regions and on the front line. Like in the eggs case, the local deficit was compensated by additional supplies of oil products from Belarus.

Despite the successful cooperation, Belarusian officials show increased resentment about Russia's support of its last ally being not enough. At the meeting of prime ministers, Halouchanka said that he was dissatisfied with the quality of Russian investments, and the Ambassador to Russia Krutoy repeatedly complained that Russia imported too much from China, and Belarusian producers were unable to compete with it. Finally, during several highest-level meetings held over the reporting period, the issue of additional investments in the Russian railway and port infrastructure was raised at least twice in order to increase the potential of Belarusian exports. The amount in question is about $1.5–3 billion. Minsk most likely expected that the Russian infrastructure would be expanded at the Russian expense, but so far it has not been possible to persuade Putin to do it. To attract new Russian loans, Lukashenka even began to look for workarounds. For example, although the capacities of the first nuclear power plant turned out to be unpopular, Lukashenka began to suggest building another plant.

NO NEW SANCTIONS ARE IMPOSED, BUT THE PREVIOUS ONES MAY INTENSIFY

In February, the EU adopted the 13th package of sanctions against Russia and Belarus. The new package mainly includes companies associated with the Russian military-industrial complex, as well as the companies that helped bypass previously adopted sanctions. The new package of sanctions

does not imply a significant expansion of restrictions and is unlikely to be a strong additional blow to the economy of Belarus. Along with the adoption of another package of sanctions, in March, the EU Parliament made a decision which looks quite innovative. According to the new decree, bypassing sanctions should be considered a criminal offence, so after this measure is adopted in national jurisdictions, it may significantly affect the degree of implementation of all the previous sanctions.

In February-May, the Baltic states and Poland continued to complicate border controls for Belarusian goods. Inspections of goods exported from and imported into the EU have been intensified, and logistics costs have increased accordingly.

The proposal of Latvia, Lithuania and Poland to impose restrictions on Russian and Belarusian agricultural products, adopted by the EU Council in May, was another innovation. Such restrictions are rare in world practice, as they are extremely unpopular in the Global South countries and may undermine food security for the poorest and most vulnerable countries. Belarus is not an important exporter of grain, and Russia mainly export its grain not to Europe but elsewhere. Thus, restrictions on grain exports are unlikely to have any consequences.

Several big Belarusian state-owned companies tried to appeal against their inclusion in the sanctions lists over the past three years, but none of the appeals were successful until March 2024. On 30 March, the EU General Court decided to lift sanctions against Belshina because the enterprise was unprofitable. If the case becomes a precedent, it will give Belarusian enterprises some opportunities to avoid sanctions. The lifting of sanctions against an enterprise does not in any way exempt it from the sectoral sanctions adopted separately, so Belarusian tires are not to be expected on the European market any time soon. However, the cancellation of personal sanctions will make other types of potential communication of the enterprise with European counterparties easier.

5 POLITICAL COMMUNICATION

The polarisation of opinions on digital platforms keeps increasing. While the Belarusian democratic forces are actively supporting Ukraine and calling for increased pressure on the Alyaksandr Lukashenka regime, the pro-government segment relies on promoting its narratives on TikTok. In the reporting period, pro-government speakers intensified the ideological component and political support for Russia in their narrative. At the same time, the main narratives of pro-democratic speakers remain the same: nostalgia for the 2020 protests and discrediting of the regime's domestic political actions. If earlier pro-democratic speakers were cautious about promoting the idea of the European future for Belarus, in spring this message became more popular on online platforms.

METHODOLOGY

In this section, we analysed which narratives were promoted by pro-government and pro-democratic speakers online, what tactics they used to communicate with the audience and which events they covered in March-May 2024[1]. The analysis is based on the publications in 48 TikTok accounts for the period of 1-22 May and in 40 Telegram channels for the period of 1 March – 31 May. It is important to note that the analysis was aimed specifically at reviewing the narratives and goals of communication of pro-government and pro-democratic speakers, not at evaluating the effectiveness of the communication of channels and accounts with the audience[2].

WAR IN UKRAINE REMAINS THE CENTRAL EVENT

In the reporting period, the pro-government and pro-democratic speakers covered both domestic and foreign events. The focus was on news, analytical and critical opinions about events in Ukraine, Russia and inside the country.

In March, the attention of the pro-government and pro-democratic authors was mostly focused on the terrorist attack in Crocus City Hall. The pro-democratic speakers connected this event to another day important for Russia — the presidential election held on 17 March. A significant share of publications in the pro-democratic segment was covering Freedom Day and related events.

In April, the pro-government speakers dedicated most of their publications to the All-Belarusian People's Assembly election, while the pro-democratic channels condemned and actively discredited this event. In turn, the election to the Coordination Council (CC), which became the main event covered in the pro-democratic segment in May, were ignored by most pro-government authors. The April publications of both political poles concerned Maryna Vasileuskaya's flight into space. For the pro-government speakers, the news became a matter of pride — it was portrayed as the country's achievement. The pro-democratic channels ridiculed and condemned this event.

In May, Victory Day was the most important event on the agenda of the pro–government speakers and second important event on the agenda of the pro-democratic ones. The event accumulated strong ideological charge: praise in the pro–government segment and condemning in the pro-democratic

[1] Подробное описание методологии, а также полный список проанализированных Телеграм-каналов и ТикТок-аккаунтов можно найти в Техническом приложении №1

[2] Такие оценки проводились в других исследованиях, например: Analysis of political propaganda on TikTok: identification and monitoring of pro-regime, pro-democracy and pro-kremlin narratives / ISANS, March 2024

one. Unlike last year[3], this time the pro-government speakers demonstrated an even greater desire to confirm the historical and inevitable connection to Russia through communication.

> "The greatest Day in history. The day we won. The whole united Europe was defeated. The Red Army extinguished the furnaces of the concentration camps. The Red Army took Berlin. The Red Army gave the world a chance to exist. The Red Army, invincible, legendary, great, after four terrible years, planted its Banner in the enemy's lair. Do not trust the treacherous "allies". It was them who helped Hitler rise. Even in April-May 1945, they were ready to begin an assault against us together with the Germans. Only our overwhelming power scared them off. As our Father rightly said, the Truth about that Victory protects us today. The great soldiers and marshals of those days now stand together with our fighters on the border, by our air defence, in command posts with our generals. And Generalissimo is also with them. As long as we do not betray them, they are with us. Happy Holiday! Happy Great Victory Day!"[4]

The pro-government speakers also did not miss the opportunity to promote the news about former Polish judge Tomasz Szmydt who fled to Belarus. Both the pro-government and pro-democratic channels also talk about visits of their political leaders. For example, in May, Telegram channels actively covered Lukashenka's trip to Azerbaijan.

Meanwhile, the pro-democratic authors kept focus on the election to the Coordination Council and the preceding conference of democratic forces in Warsaw. Besides campaign publications, these authors compared the democratic procedures of the CC election to the staged performance of the Belarusian authorities during the election to the All-Belarusian People's Assembly. Anatol Liabiedzka:

> "Do you remember any decisions of the ABPA that made you happier and richer? Not Lukashenka, Kachanava or Karpiankou, but you? [...In the new Belarus, the principle of power distribution will be restored, and the parliament will regain its authority. It will consist of deputies elected in a free and fair election, accountable only to the voter."[5]

Throughout the reporting period, the events of the war in Ukraine remained the most popular topic of both the pro-government and pro-democratic channels. On TikTok, the war in Ukraine becomes the subject of videos of both political poles much less often than, for example, sketches about joint military exercises of Russia and Belarus and demonstration of the military power of the Belarusian army. At the same time, in April, the pro-government Telegram segment covered the conflict in Ukraine even more actively than the ABPA election (32%). The share of publications mentioning the war in Ukraine reached 32%, compared to 6% in March and 10% in May. The pro-democratic content creators had three times fewer materials about the war in Ukraine in April.

[3] A similar analysis was performed by a research team in 2023: Rudnik, A. Digital transformation trends in Belarusian democratic resistance: Narratives, Perceptions, and Reaction of the State / FES, October 2023

[4] Azarenok. STV. Belarus, 9 May, 06:54

[5] Sviatlana Tsikhanouskaya, 25 April, 19:02

Table 5.1. Top 3 events covered by the pro-government and pro–democratic content creators in March-May

	Pro-government	% of publications in the sample	Pro-democratic	% of publications in the sample
March	1. Attack at Crocus City Ha	21.3%	1. 1. Attack at Crocus City Hall	17%
	2. War in Ukraine	6.3%	2. Freedom Day	9.4%
	3. Maryna Vasileuskaya's flight into space	5.8%	3. Election in Russia	6%
April	1. War in Ukraine	31.5%	1. ABPA	15.4%
	2. ABPA	24%	2. Maryna Vasileuskaya's flight into space	6.9%
	3. Maryna Vasileuskaya's flight into space	8.9%	3. War in Ukraine	9.4%
May[6]	1. Victory Day	24.8%	1. Election to the CC	27%
	2. War in Ukraine	9.5%	2. Victory Day	7,7%
	3. Day of the National Symbols	4.9%	3. Conference of the Democratic Forces on 19 May, Warsaw	6.5%

POLARISATION OF OPINIONS IS INCREASING

In March and May, the pro–democratic and pro-government speakers promoted a number of recurring messages, which we grouped into the main narratives shown in Table 2. In the reporting period, we have observed a pronounced polarisation of opinions on online platforms, which is reflected not only in the publications of the representatives of political structures, but also among independent content creators.

The polarisation is manifested in the active discrediting of supporters of the opposing political party, with increasing degree of criticism and normalisation of previously seemingly radical ideas. For the pro-government authors, discrediting is often accompanied by aggressive rhetorical and visual techniques.

> "Cultural news of zmahar-fighters: grateful colleagues want to dedicate a mural to Poczobut, Rabkova and Bialiatski somewhere in Poland. Makes no difference where it'll be, caring for Polish cities is Polacks' business. What's interesting is that lately, murals have been dedicated to dead people. It's kind of a surrogate for a stone or bronze monument when they are too expensive to make. So it seems our quasi-fighters have already buried Poczobut and his prison buddies. Well, we should admit they would benefit more from dead Poczobut. Who the hell needs him, except for

6 Hereinafter, the data for May are provided for both platforms (Telegram and TikTok)

his family — but if you have a dead body, you can parade it around an embassy, or bring it out on some other cheerful occasions."[7]

Also, in the hundreds of messages that we registered, there has been practically no articulation of thoughts common for both segments. Different national symbols, origins of statehood, interpretation of holidays (Freedom Day and Victory Day are great examples of that from the reporting period), understanding of the country's current standing in the international context – in each of these aspects, the pro–government and pro-democratic authors not only have a position opposite to the one of the other side, but also actively set their symbols against the opposing ones. Such disagreement is a symptom of the increasing polarisation of opinions on the majority of issues: from the domestic political situation to the assessment of events of the war in Ukraine and relations between Russia and Europe.

The only common message that casually passes through the articulated agenda of both segments is the idea that Belarus is a peaceful country, and Belarusians want peace. The main difference is that the pro-government speakers see Lukashenka as a guarantor of peace for Belarus, while the pro-democratic authors see him as the main and immediate thre.

Table 5.2. Key narratives of pro-government and pro-democratic speakers

Pro-government narratives	Pro-democratic narratives
Lukashenka is a competent and wise ruler who controls the successful development of the country and guarantees its independence.	The level of repressions is increasing, Belarusian security forces are crossing all possible lines; political prisoners who have become victims of the repressive machine need more active support.
Belarus and Russia are reliable partners who support each other no matter what, friendly relations between the countries are strengthening, despite the turbulence in the region and the attempts of Western countries to crush and prevent the development of Belarus and Russia.	Lukashenka is a dictator who caused a political crisis and dragged Belarus into supporting Russian aggression in Ukraine. His political actions are criminal, and his officials are cogs in a deceitful and cruel repressive system. At the same time, his position is shaky, his health is failing him, people do not support him.
The opposition are traitors who must be punished, they are only interested in using the resources of Western countries for self–enrichment.	The crisis in the country is catastrophic: the economy is sinking, prices are rising, and education becomes increasingly riddled with ideological and Russian narratives.
Western countries are having a crisis of values and political turmoil, they seek to stir unrest around the world and are reluctant to support Ukraine.	Russia is not a friendly country for Belarus, but only a threat to stability, culture, education and the country's future as a whole. Belarusians support Ukraine, which is actively fighting for its independence.
Belarus is a peaceful country that is focused on the development of the state for its citizens, however, if necessary, the Belarusian army and the political elite are ready to deal with any threat.	Belarus is a European country in terms of both values and politics. This idea is shared by Belarusians and their European partners that actively support the Belarusian people. However, there is not enough practical support for

[7] Желтые сливы, 16 апреля, 15:50

	ordinary Belarusians (visas, open borders, scholarships for students from Belarus). The future of Belarus is in Europe.
The Ukrainian authorities are criminals who involved ordinary citizens in a war Ukrainians did not want to fight. Part of the population betrayed the memory of their ancestors and was influenced by Nazi ideas.	The democratic forces are able to overcome any crisis with the support of a strong diaspora and civic initiatives; the democratic forces, unlike Lukashenka, think about the Belarusian people.

STRUGGLE FOR PUBLIC OPINION: ALL TACTICS ARE USED

In modern authoritarian regimes, digital platforms and social networks are used for various purposes. Researchers often identify four main categories among them. First is legitimation, defined as an attempt to justify a certain action, event or statement in order to improve the image, emphasise that the decisions were correct, or attempt to justify and explain certain decisions[8]. Second is discrediting, which is the articulation of criticism or accusations against an opposing political subject or a group of people[9]. Third is ideologisation, which is the articulation of a set of ideas, values, a picture of the world or the historical importance of people and events[10]. Fourth is manipulation, which is an attempt to present facts or events through an alternative point of view in order to distort perception[11]. We have used these four categories as our main analysis tool. We analysed each message to find out if it contains features of one or more categories. During the analysis of the pro-government and pro-democratic Telegram channels and TikTok accounts, we have seen that both the pro-government and pro-democratic speakers turn to all four tactics of communication with the audience.

The pro-government segment's use of manipulation, which we interpreted as the presentation of incorrect facts and false or distorted interpretation of facts in order to distort the opinion of readers, reached its peak in March (20%), when the terrorist attack at Crocus City Hall was the main event for the pro-government speakers. The use of manipulation by the pro-democratic authors was observed by the research team less often (4%), but it concerned the same event.

In the pro-government segment, we have noticed the largest number of attributes of the legitimation category. The number of such publications amounts to 27% and is mainly based on the articulation of the successes of domestic political decisions, the regime's individual political players (for example, Interior Minister Kubrakou), economic decisions and successful repressions against dissidents. In April, the pro-government speakers actively promoted the election to the All-Belarusian People's Assembly as a way to update the system, make it more transparent and involve broad groups of citizens. Also, in April, the authorities focused on the successful space flight of Belarusian Maryna Vasileuskaya, who dedicated her achievement to the Belarusian people under red and green banners.

[8] Rudnik, A. 'Co-option of technology: Digital repression and legitimation strategies of the Belarusian regime' / Communist and Post-Communist studies, 2024

[9] Munger K., Bonneau R., Nagler J., Tucker J. A. "Elites tweet to get feet off the streets: Measuring regime social media strategies during protest." / Political Science Research and Methods 7, 2019 (no. 4: 815–834)

[10] von Soest, Christian, and Grauvogel, Julia. "Identity, procedures and performance: How authoritarian regimes legitimize their rule." / Contemporary Politics 23, 2017 (no. 3: 287–305)

[11] MacKinnon R. "Liberation technology: China's 'networked authoritarianism'." / Journal of Democracy 22, 2011 (no. 2: 32–46)

> "And just like that, a person has become a legend, a part of our history. Maryna Vasileuskaya will carry the burden of this responsibility for the rest of her life. I'm sure she'll do great! Politically, it is a triumph of the Belarusian development model focused on allied relations with Russia."[12]

This month, the share of publications with attributes of legitimation reached 42%, which is eight times higher than their May share. In May, the pro-government speakers focused on Lukashenka's visit to Azerbaijan, justifying the importance of this event for improving the country's international image. The pro-democratic content creators also chose similar grounds for legitimisation, focusing on Tsikhanouskaya's international trips. They also used the election to the Coordination Council as the main subject of their legitimation publications.

In the pro-democratic channels and accounts, we have most frequently observed the attributes of the discrediting of political opponents. In April, criticism, condemnation and exposure on online platforms reached its peak, when 62% of the publications of the pro-democratic segment in Telegram discredited the regime representatives due to the ABPA meeting and the domestic political situation. The pro-government speakers also used discrediting as a popular tactic. Remarkably, from March to May, the number of publications with critical, condemning and insulting messages towards opponents decreased by half (from 30% to 14%). We attribute this to the active criticism of Freedom Day by the pro-government segment in March.

The use of ideologisation attributes was observed as a communication tactic in 12% of the materials of the pro-government and 3% of the materials of the pro-democratic segment. In May, ideological publications prevailed over other categories (20% compared to 8% and 6% in the previous months) due to Victory Day, the most popular event among the pro–government authors. Given the eight-fold drop in legitimation publications and the twofold increase in ideological publications, it is safe to assume that the resources of the pro-government speakers were simultaneously redistributed to cover Victory Day from the ideological perspective. Ideological publications reached their peak in the pro–democratic segment in March (13%), exceeding the share of such publications in April by 8 times and in May by 2 times.

NOSTALGIA FOR A DIFFERENT PAST, VISION OF A DIFFERENT FUTURE

Along with these political communication trends, in the reporting period, we have observed clear difference in the vision of Belarus's place in the past and in the future. While the pro-government authors feel very nostalgic for historical figures of the USSR and appeal to the increasing unity with Russia, the pro-democratic speakers are nostalgic about the 2020 protests and advocate the idea of Belarus's European future.

The articulation of the idea of the European future is gradually increasing in the pro-democratic segment compared to last year[13]. It is manifested in both finding historical common grounds and claiming that the Belarusian people already share the values of Western countries.

> Europe goes beyond geography. It is a community that believes in human rights, democracy and the rule of law. These values are exactly what many Belarusians are fighting for."[14]

Political actors among the pro-democratic speakers are more confident in voicing the European choice as a geopolitical focus and the EU as a future ally of Belarus, which already supports civil society initiatives and continues to put pressure on the Lukashenka regime. At the same time, the coverage of this topic has acquired a new remarkable touch – justification for a practical separation of the Belarusian political regime and the Belarusian people.

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[12] Shpakousky. Po sushchestvu (Speaking to the point), 6 April, 12:25

[13] Rudnik, A. Digital transformation trends in Belarusian democratic resistance: Narratives, Perceptions, and Reaction of the State / FES, October 2023.

[14] Светлана Тихановская, 7 марта, 07:29

Among the pro-government speakers, the distance between the idea of supporting Lukashenka as the country's leader and a guarantor of independence and the idea of friendly relations with Russia, which will help overcome any challenges together, is shortening. If earlier support for the narrative of mutually beneficial friendly relations with Russia was expressed by one group of speakers, and the role of Lukashenka as a guarantor of stability was promoted by another group, recently these messages have often been published by the same authors.

The pro-government authors also promote a for now unpopular but fairly new message of Belarus's separation from international law and standards. This is manifested in the articulation of the idea that Belarus, together with Russia, has its own unique path, and on this path international and Western guidelines are no longer relevant.

6 PUBLIC OPINION DYNAMICS

Public opinion remains politically polarised: the shares of supporters and opponents of the current government remain unchanged, and the extreme segments still have a very negative attitude towards each other. At the same time, general satisfaction with the socio-economic situation in the country is growing, which may affect the balance of political views in the future. Belarusians are also actively assimilating the main strategic narratives of pro-government propaganda: the only exception is ardent opponents of the regime who support the ideas promoted by pro-democratic speakers. The war continues to simultaneously divide and unite Belarusians: supporters of the regime sympathise with Russia, while opponents support Ukraine; however, both oppose the involvement of Belarus in military operations. At the same time, doubt about Ukraine's victory has significantly increased over the analysed period.

ON THE INTERPRETATION OF THE SURVEY RESULTS

To properly understand the results of the research used in the Belarus Change Tracker, it is necessary to take into account the specifics of our data collection method. We conduct a survey based on an online panel, and our sample represents not the entire society but the panel participants. At the same time, the changes we observe among 70,000–100,000 panellists reflect the trends of public opinion among all Belarusians[1].

What our **research does show**?

- The dynamics of public opinion. We monitor the changes in the survey panel and interpret these dynamics as an indicator of changes in wider society. For example, if we see that the friendly attitude towards Russian nuclear weapons has changed by ±5 percentage points, we can assume that there are potential changes in the public opinion of Belarusians. If we see a difference of ± 15 percentage points, we can definitely assume there are significant changes.
- Differences between society segments. Our survey reflects the structure of opinions within each segment of society. For example, we can estimate with great accuracy how well **ardent opponents** of the current government are aware of the election to the Coordination Council.

What our **research does NOT show**?

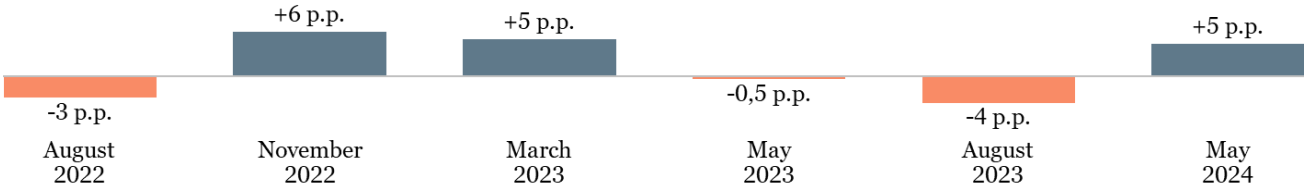
The exact size of the segments and the distribution of opinions in wiser society. We do not know exactly how many people in Belarusian society are inclined to trust or distrust the regime, or how many people support Russia or Ukraine in the war. We intentionally do not show the general distributions in the sample, because if these figures are published in the media, for example, they may contribute to an erroneous understanding of the socio-political situation in the country.

[1] See the Technical Annex 2 for details.

SHARES OF THE REGIME SUPPORTERS AND OPPONENTS HAVE NOT CHANGED, OVERALL SATISFACTION WITH THE SITUATION IN THE COUNTRY IS GROWING

The size of the conflicting political segments has not changed significantly in the last nine months since they were last measured. Figure 6.1 shows that the segment of **moderate supporters**[2] increased by 5 percentage points compared to August 2023, which may be a statistical error. That said, if the next measurement also shows increasing trust in the government, it will become a trend.

Figure 6.1. Change in the share of the aggregated Supporters segment relative to the previous measurement (in percentage points)



The figure shows the difference between the share of the Supporters (ardent supporters + moderate supporters) in the specified month and their share during the previous measurement. For example, in August 2022, the segment decreased by 3 percentage points compared to May 2022, and in November 2022 it increased by 6 percentage points compared to August 2022.

Thus, the dynamics of the size of social conflict segments is still on the plateau. In November 2022 and March 2023, we observed a gradual increase in trust in the government. By May 2023, this trend stopped, and after that, the ratio of conflict segments has remained virtually unchanged until today.

Despite the overall situation is still on the plateau, the dynamics of more specific indicators shows that the government is gradually strengthening its positions.

For example, the current measurement has confirmed the trend of the decrease in the **ardent opponents** segment. Their share has been gradually decreasing since August 2022 and by today's measurement has reached a statistically significant gap compared to the initial figure. This dynamics can be attributed to both increasing depoliticisation and mass migration, which, according to the latest data, accounts for about 220,000 people who left for the EU alone[3].

Also, from August 2023 to May 2024, satisfaction with the situation in the country significantly increased. According to the Social Sentiment Index (SSI)[4] (Figure 6.2), Belarusians now have higher average opinion of the political situation and greater satisfaction with both the well-being of their own families and the country on the whole. This trend is also confirmed by the growth of the Consumer Confidence Index from Q3–2023 to Q2–2024[5].

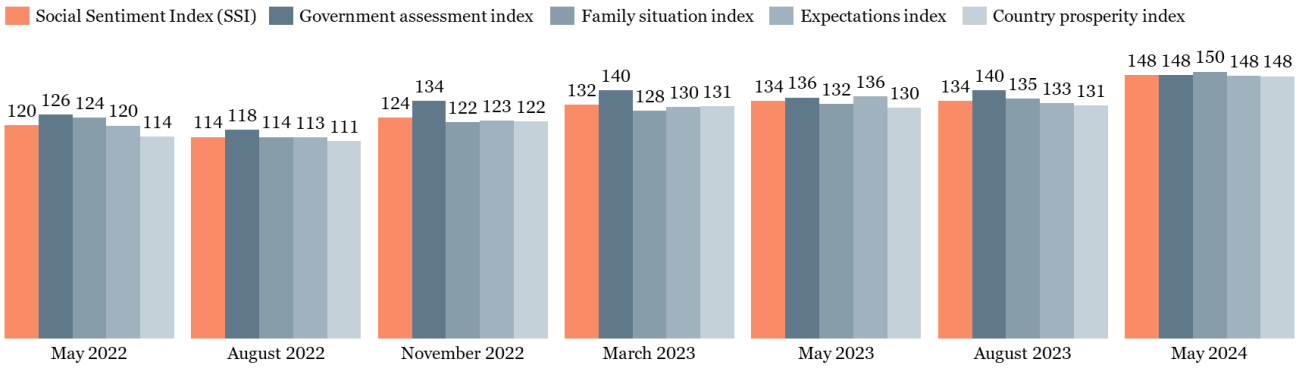
[2] In order to track the dynamics of political sentiment in the Belarusian society, we identify Social Conflict Segments (SCSs). These segments are based on the level of trust in the pro-government and opposing subjects: the police, the KGB, the armed forces, state and non-state media, political prisoners, etc. The segments are formed mathematically with cluster analysis. As a result, we have four groups: ardent supporters, moderate supporters, moderate opponents and ardent opponents. The aggregated Supporters segment consists of the total of ardent supporters and moderate supporters.

[3] Коршунаў, Г. Дык колькі беларусаў з'ехала? / Цэнтр новых ідэй, май 2024.

4 To track the dynamics of assessments of the socio-political situation in the country, we use the Social Sentiment Index (SSI), which consists of four indicators: 1) A government assessment index (GI), reflecting the level of approval of the state authorities in the country; 2) A family situation index (FI), reflecting respondents' subjective assessments of the emotional and material situation of their families; 3) An expectations index (EI), reflecting people's perceptions of their personal future and that of the country; 4) A country prosperity index (PI), combining assessments of the economic and political situation of the country as a whole.

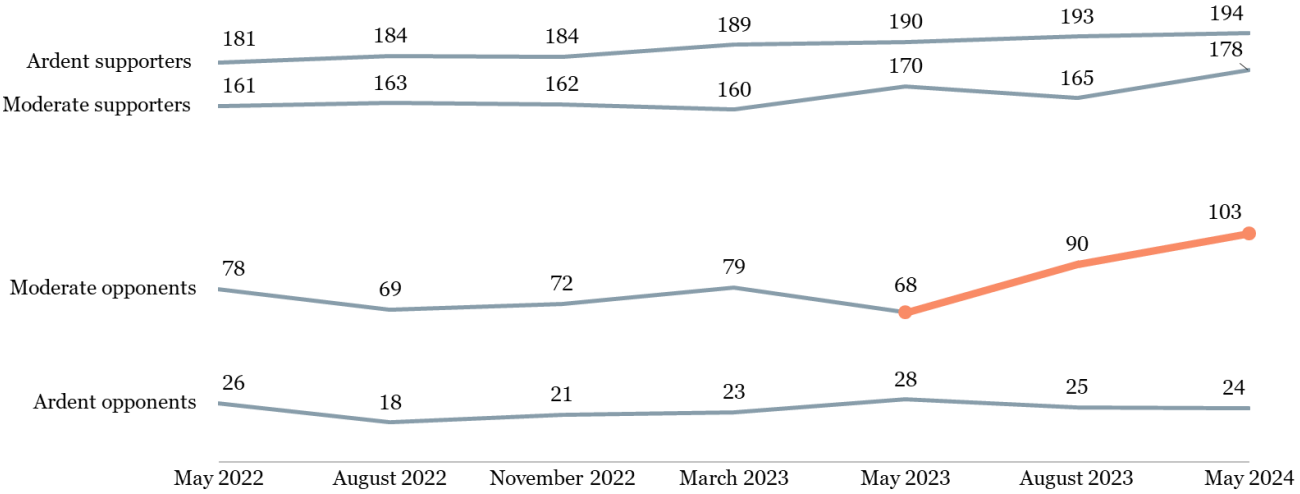
[5] Доходы и потребительская уверенность домохозяйств в мае 2024 / BEROC, июнь 2024.

Figure 6.2. Social Sentiment Index dynamics, scale from 1 to 200



The overall improvement in the perception of the situation was mainly attributed to the improved assessments of **moderate opponents** (Figure 6.3). The Social Sentiment Index increased significantly within this segment during the previous measurement, and the current wave confirmed this dynamics. **Moderate supporters** also began to perceive the situation as a much better one compared to 2023, although the growth was not so strong.

Figure 6.3. Social Sentiment Index dynamics by segments, scale from 1 to 200

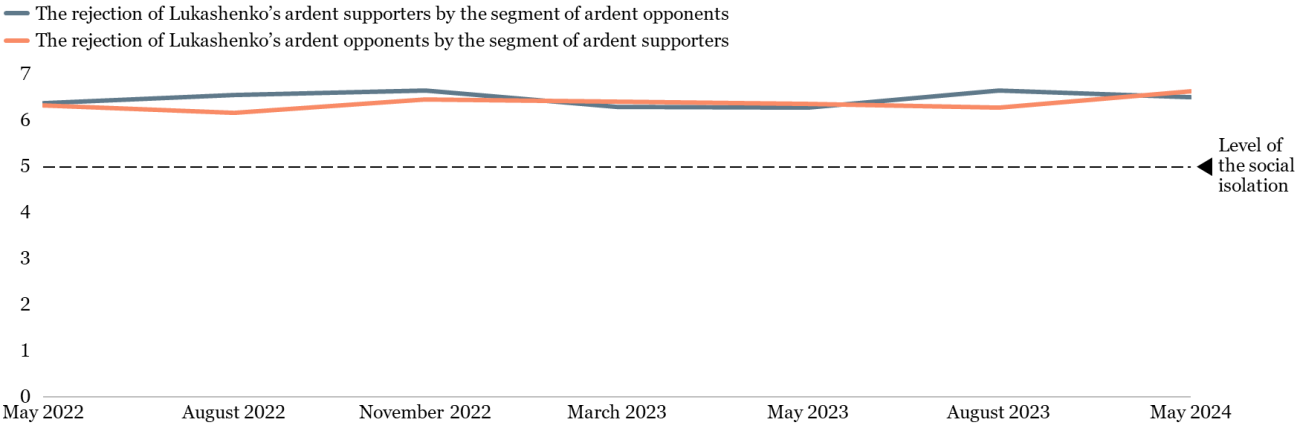


Since the measurements started, **ardent supporters** gradually improved their attitude to the situation, and in May 2023 these changes already became significant. The trend was confirmed in the previous and current waves when the SSI in this segment practically reached its peak.

Thus, in terms of the ratio of the shares of the aggregated conflict segments, the political sentiments of Belarusians remain the same as was observed in the previous report. At the same time, the overall assessment of the situation in the country has improved significantly, mainly due to **moderate opponents**. If this trend persists, positive assessments of the socio-economic situation are likely to result in increased trust in the government – we will continue to monitor this trend in subsequent issues.

While the assessments of the situation in the country have improved, we do not observe any decrease in the intensity of the social conflict in terms of the attitude of its sides to each other. The social distance score still shows a high level of rejection between the extreme segments of the conflict (Figure 6.4). The level of rejection of the opposite group is above the level of social isolation, and for both segments their opponents are the most unacceptable group. For example, **ardent supporters**, though usually xenophobic, are still more often ready to accept representatives of sexual minorities in society than accept ardent opponents of Lukashenka.

Figure 6.4. Level of social distance between the segments of the social conflict as opposed to each other, scale from 1 to 7, where 7 is maximum rejection



Evaluate what kind of relationship with representatives of different groups or nationalities is acceptable to you personally. Finish the statement: I do not mind having the representatives of this group as...
1 — close members of my family, 2 – my relatives, 3 – my friends, 4 – my colleagues, 5 – my neighbours, 6 – people living with me in the same house, 7 — would not wish to see them in my country.

Summing up, we see that the dynamics of the sizes of the political segments in Belarus remains unchanged, although there is some increase in satisfaction with the situation in the country. The conflict sides still have a strong rejection of each other. In this regard, the regime is failing to achieve a "national consensus" by removing contradictions between the conflicting segments of society, and some acceptance of the authorities is achieved mainly by suppressing their opponents.

RUSSIAN-UKRAINIAN WAR IN THE CONTEXT OF SOCIAL CONFLICT: GROWING DOUBT ABOUT UKRAINE'S VICTORY

The increased doubt about Ukraine's victory has been the main change in the perception of the war over the past nine months. This trend affected all the segments except for **ardent supporters**, who had already believed that Russia was winning. Even among **ardent opponents**, the share of those who believed that Ukraine was winning the war decreased from 48% to 12%: instead, they were more often inclined to believe that the sides were in the equal position or even that Russia was winning. This trend may be the result of events unfavourable for Ukraine, which were widely covered in state and non-state media: problems with the supply of American weapons and the Russian offensive in the Kharkiv oblast.

Figure 6.1. Perception of the Russian-Ukrainian war

Statistically significant changes compared to August 2023, within the segment

Significantly higher than among other segments

		Ardent supporters	Moderate supporters	Moderate opponents	Ardent opponents
The Russian-Ukrainian war has been going on since 24 February 2022. Which of the three statements about the Belarusian army better reflects your opinion?	It should take part in the war on the side of Ukraine	1%	1%	0,5%	16%
	It should take part in the war on the side of Russia	10%	7%	3%	0,3%
	It should not take part in the war on either side	89%	92%	96%	83%

		Ardent supporters	Moderate supporters	Moderate opponents	Ardent opponents
Which side, in your opinion, is currently winning the Russian-Ukrainian war?	Ukraine is winning	1%	1%	2%	12% ↓
	Russia is winning	63%	51% ↑	36% ↑	16% ↑
	Both countries are in a roughly equal position	5%	6%	19%	39% ↑
	Difficult to answer	31%	43%	42% ↓	33%
To what extent do you agree or disagree with the following statement? Russia made a mistake when it started military action in Ukraine in 2022.	Completely disagree	42%	21%	18%	9%
	Rather disagree	42%	46%	17%	1%
	Rather agree	13%	28%	36%	14%
	Completely agree	2%	5%	30%	75%
In the new phase of the hostilities in Ukraine, which started on 24 February 2022, are you rather supporting Ukraine or Russia? Or none of them fully?	Rather Ukraine	1%	4%	18%	82%
	Rather Russia	62%	50%	22% ↑	1%
	None of them fully	12%	23%	36%	15%
	Difficult to answer	25%	23%	24%	2%
How much do you agree or disagree with the following statement about nuclear weapons in Belarus? I welcome the deployment of nuclear weapons in the territory of Belarus.	Completely agree	38% ↑	16%	8%	0,3%
	Rather agree	21%	22%	6%	2%
	Rather disagree	10%	27%	25%	2%
	Completely disagree	12%	12%	42%	93%
	Difficult to answer	18%	22%	19%	3%

Apart from the above-mentioned changes in the perception of a potential winner, there have been no significant shifts in the perception of the war.

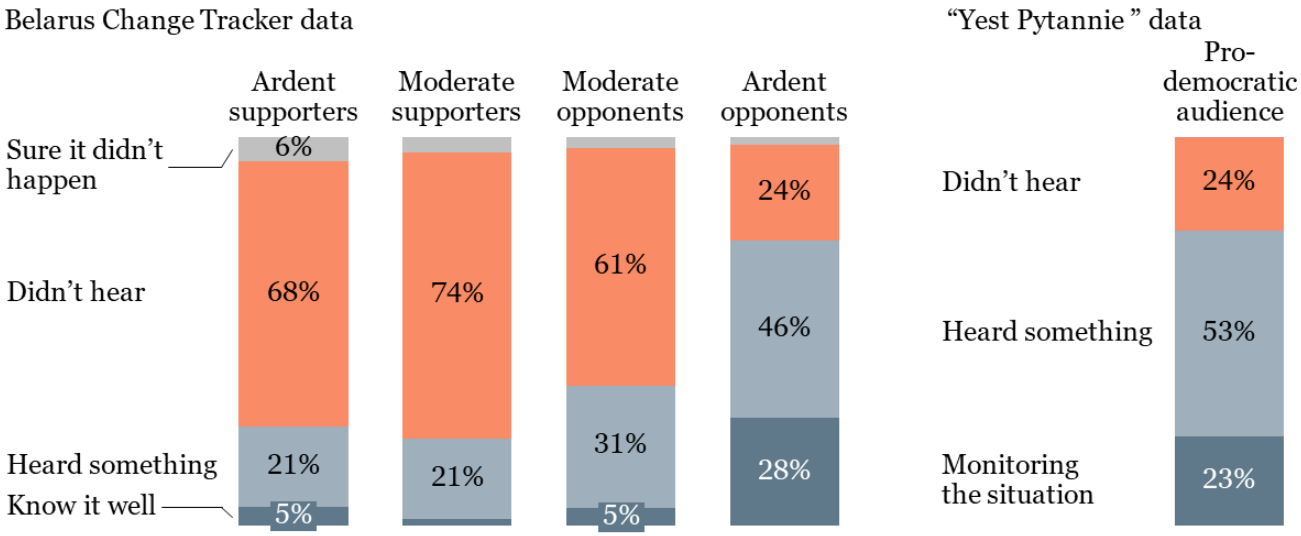
The anti-war consensus in Belarusian society remains unchanged: the overwhelming majority does not support Belarus's participation in the war. In the subsection "Assimilation of political narratives", we show how the speakers of the current government successfully use these sentiments of Belarusians in their favour.

At the same time, the war is still one of the conflict topics: the sympathies of **ardent supporters** are rather on Russia's side, while **ardent opponents** unequivocally support Ukraine.

ELECTION TO THE COORDINATION COUNCIL

The election to the Coordination Council (CC) failed to become a significant event for Belarusians. Only about 30% of **ardent opponents** were well aware of it, and most respondents from other segments did not hear anything about this election.

Table 6.5. Awareness of the election to the Coordination Council



There are several events before you. For each of them, please answer: do you know all about it, heard something before or hear about it for the first time now? Election to the Coordination Council (CC; Kaardynatsyinaya Rada, KR). Source: Yest Pytannie (I have a question) Survey about the election to the Coordination Council, May 2024.

Our data on the awareness of ardent opponents coincides with the result of a survey of the pro-democratic audience conducted by the initiative "Yest Pytannie" (I have a question)[6]. The fact that the independently obtained results coincide mutually validates our approaches to data collection. Since the Yest Pytannie survey predicted the election results quite accurately (the maximum margin of error was 10 percentage points), we can assume that it accurately represents the active pro-democratic part of Belarusians. That is why below we use these data for analysing the perception of the election to the Coordination Council.

Although half of the pro-democratic Belarusians (47%) claimed that the event was important and necessary in the current conditions, they did not show any desire to participate in it personally. Only 26% said that they planned to vote, 22% learned how to vote for the lists, 11% looked through the lists. At the same time, pro-democratic Belarusians abroad turned out to be much more involved in the process in terms of all these indicators.

Perhaps one of the reasons for the reluctance to participate in the vote was poor understanding of the list system. The majority (65%) of those who heard about the election found it difficult to answer a question about their attitude to this system.

Another reason for the low interest may have been fear for safety. Among the pro-democratic Belarusians who heard about the election, the majority (60%) expressed uncertainty about the safety of voting.

In addition, the low interest in the CC election could be attributed to not so active coverage of this event by pro-democratic speakers until May (see Table 5.1 in Section 5).

ASSIMILATION OF POLITICAL NARRATIVES

In this wave of research, we wanted to analyse how exactly the audience assimilated the main narratives that are broadcast by pro-government or pro-democratic speakers. We made a questionnaire containing 26 statements (18 of them are narratives of pro–government speakers, 8 are pro–democratic), which reflect the main ideas in the speakers' discourse in the period from 1

[6] Апытанне да выбараў у Каардынацыйную Раду / Ёсць пытанне, май 2024.

March to 22 April 2024, based on the narratives identified during the analysis for section "Political communication Respondents were asked to assess to what extent they agreed or disagreed with these statements. Based on their responses, we divided the audience into four segments[7], depending on the extent to which the narratives of pro–government and pro-democratic media were assimilated, and also made a general assessment of which narratives were assimilated by the public and which were rejected.

SEGMENTATION OF COMMITMENT TO NARRATIVES

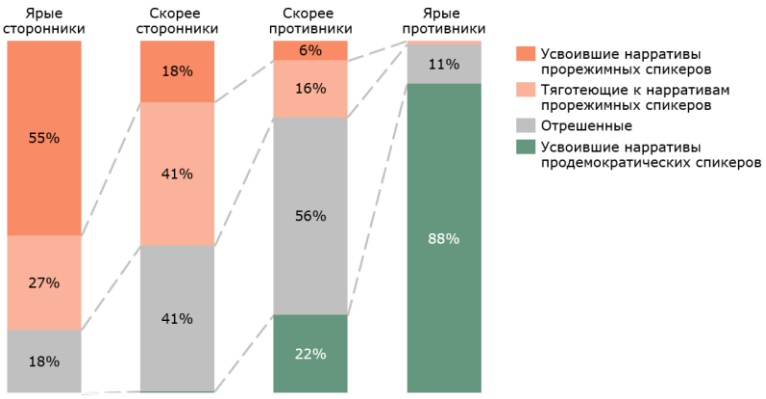
The entire sample of respondents was divided into the following segments:

- **Those who assimilated the narratives of pro-government speakers.** Representatives of this segment are characterised by an extremely high degree of agreement with the narratives aimed at discrediting the West. For them, Lukashenka is the guarantor of stability, sovereignty and economic success of Belarus. They more often than others disagree with the statements about Lukashenka's dependence on Russia and about Russia being about to drag Belarus into a war. They often see the opponents of the current Belarusian government as enemies who should be punished.
- **Gravitating to the narratives of pro-government speakers.** This segment, although generally similar to the previous one, since it has mostly assimilated the same narratives, nevertheless agrees with these statements to a significantly lesser extent and more often chooses "Difficult to answer" option. In fact, the key difference is the attitude towards repressions in the country and opponents of the regime: e.g. if those who have assimilated the narratives of pro-government media often deny the fact of repressions, most of those who are gravitating to pro-government narratives find it difficult to express an opinion about this statement.
- **Detached.** This segment probably consumes political media content less often than others, so it assimilates narratives worse than others. Mostly, they are much less likely to agree with the statements praising Lukashenka or criticising Western countries. They also tend to criticise the authorities more often and are more likely to believe that Lukashenka is rebuilding the system of power in the Republic of Belarus for his resignation.
- **Those who assimilated the narratives of pro-democratic speakers.** This segment fully supports the claims of pro-democratic speakers and rejects the claims of pro-government ones. They consider Russia a threat to the country's sovereignty. Lukashenka is perceived as a puppet of the Kremlin and the most corrupt official in the country. They are convinced that mass persecution for political position is taking place in Belarus.

When these segments intersect with the SCSs, we can see that the majority of **ardent supporters** and **ardent opponents** consists of those who have assimilated the narratives of pro-government and pro-democratic speakers respectively (Figure 6.6). **Moderate supporters** mostly consist of the detached and those gravitating to pro-government narratives, but **moderate opponents** mostly consist of the detached.

This is another proof that the conflicting parties live in their

Рисунок 6.5 Пересечение сегментов социального



[7] See the Technical Annex 2 for more information about the Segmentation of commitment to narratives.

information bubbles, but, more importantly, that these bubbles form their way of thinking and attitudes towards various phenomena, facts and events.

PRO-GOVERNMENT SPEAKERS SHAPE VIEWS

From the list of statements presented to the respondents, they basically assimilated 13 narratives, which can mainly be divided into three categories:

- **Support for Lukashenka.** The most supported message among all the statements was "Lukashenka is doing everything to prevent Belarus from being dragged into the war." Not only supporters of the regime are convinced of this, but also moderate opponents and their founding segment, the detached. The audience also safely assimilated the strategic narratives of Belarusian pro-government propaganda: "Lukashenka is successfully fighting corruption," "It will be better if Lukashenka stays in power as long as possible," "Lukashenka forces officials to work for the benefit of people."
- **Discrediting of the West.** Belarusian propaganda successfully achieves the goal of demonising the enemy (in this case, the West and the United States). Mostly, the respondents support the claims that the United States is the main warmonger in the world, and the EU is a puppet of the United States; moral decay, non-existent in Belarus, prevails in the West; it is necessary to protect the youth from the influence of these values; they want to drag Belarus into a war; Western elites support Nazi ideology. This point of view is typical for the regime supporters. The detached (i.e., those who probably do not consume the content of political speakers regularly) also seem to assimilate these attitudes, albeit much more slowly.
- **The Russian Army and the alliance with Russia are a success.** Along with discrediting the West, propaganda is successfully shaping the image of Russia as a successful actor in Ukraine and a reliable ally. The respondents mostly believe that if Belarus is attacked, the Belarusian and Russian armies will be able to defend the country. This narrative is not assimilated only by ardent opponents of the government. At the same time, only ardent opponents are convinced that Belarus is preparing to join the war on Russia's side

In this case, the respondents remarkably strongly supported the statement "Government officials responsible for violence against Belarusians should be punished." Absolutely all segments mostly agree with this statement. This may be attributed to the respondents' desire to give the answer that would be "right", in their opinion, because if a person is responsible for violence, they should be brought to punishment.

PRO–DEMOCRATIC SPEAKERS LOSE

Most of the statements of the pro-democratic speakers were rejected by the audience. The audience disagrees the most with the statement that Lukashenka is the most corrupt official (probably because he is perceived as a fighter against corruption). Only **ardent opponents**, who apparently assimilated this narrative from pro-democratic media, are sure that Lukashenka is involved in corruption.

The statement that Lukashenka is not an independent politician and receives instructions from the Kremlin doesn't find much support either (except for from **ardent opponents**). The audience also does not agree that Russia is a threat to the sovereignty of Belarus and that Belarus is preparing to join the war on Russia's side.

CASES OF "IT'S NOT SO SIMPLE"

Statements on which the respondents have no prevailing opinion are mostly new (and often tactical) propaganda narratives from both the pro-government and pro-democratic speakers. They include:

- The **narrative that Lukashenka is rebuilding the system of power in the Republic of Belarus for his resignation,** which appeared during the ABPA meeting and was promoted by both the pro-government and pro-democratic speakers. It was most deeply assimilated by **ardent opponents**. The pro-government audience rather disagrees with it. This correlates with the deep conviction of the regime's supporters that the country will be better off if Lukashenka stays in power as long as possible.
- The tactical pro-government **narrative "In the near future, flows of refugees from Western countries fleeing political persecution can be expected in Belarus"**, which emerged because of judge Tomasz Szmydt's flight to Belarus from Poland. Its intention is rather to once again discredit Western countries in the eyes of Belarusian society than to convince Belarusians of a possible flow of refugees (i.e., to support the strategic narrative). Only one segment (**ardent supporters**) has rather assimilated this narrative.
- The narrative **"Belarus is a true democracy, unlike the West", which supports the discrediting of the West.** Now this message, as well as the previous one, is deeply assimilated only by **ardent supporters**.

Such statements also include those concerning the opposition. This may be probably attributed to the low awareness of Belarusians inside the country about the affairs of the Belarusian opposition and the fact that the pro-government speakers do not use such statements very often, while they keep actively using military propaganda techniques (discrediting opponents, glorifying themselves and their supporters). Remarkably, though the narrative "There is a split in the opposition" belongs to the pro-government speakers, this point of view is most strongly supported by **ardent opponents**.

The statements, about which the audience apparently has not yet formed a strong opinion, also include some statements typical of the pro-democratic speakers: "Mass persecution for a political position is taking place in Belarus," "Lukashenka's power depends entirely on support from the Kremlin," "It will soon become obvious to everyone that the Belarusian economy is falling apart." This distribution of the respondents in terms of the main strategic narratives of the pro-democratic speakers may be partially explained by the audience's concerns about the safety of the survey and the impact of the fear factor.

This group also includes a statement of the most emotional pro-government speakers, which is highly controversial for the respondents: "Those who oppose Lukashenka are traitors who must be punished." This point of view is shared only by **ardent supporters**.

EVENTS SIGNIFICANT FOR BELARUS

In order to determine which events were the most significant and memorable for Belarusians, we put the question "Do you think this event happened or did not happen in the spring of 2024 (March-May)?" in the questionnaire and showed the respondents 19 events that actually happened during this period[8]. Then, to determine the most memorable events, we subtracted the share of those who acknowledged that an event did not happen from the share of those who acknowledged that an event definitely happened. Thus, the top 10 events of this spring, as per the opinion of the respondents, were as follows:

- Attack at Crocus City Hall in Moscow;

[8] See the Technical Annex 2 to check the full list of the events.

- Victory Day celebrations in Belarus;
- Changes in legislation for individual entrepreneurs;
- Maryna Vasileuskaya's flight into space;
- Shelling of Belgorod and the Belgorod oblast;
- Lukashenka's visit to Azerbaijan;
- Shelling of Kharkiv and the Kharkiv oblast;
- Large-scale celebration of the Day of the National Flag, Emblem and Anthem;
- Congress of the renewed All-Belarusian People's Assembly (ABPA);
- Snap inspection of the air defence forces in Belarus.

The top of events is different for ardent supporters and ardent opponents. For example, the top 10 events remembered by ardent supporters included the adoption of the new military doctrine and the concept of national security of Belarus. The top 10 events for ardent opponents included protests against the 'foreign agent' law in Georgia and the violent murder of a young Belarusian woman in the centre of Warsaw.

In general, ardent opponents are much more aware of the events of this spring than the rest of the segments. Of the 19 events, they seemed to have missed only two: Lukashenka's meeting with the representatives of the Magadan oblast of the Russian Federation and the large-scale celebration of the Day of the National Flag, Emblem and Anthem. This is the only segment that knows for sure that Belarus conducted an inspection of non-strategic nuclear weapons carriers together with Russia, cyber partisans published databases of Belarusians' appeals to the KGB, Robert Fico was attacked, and Polish judge Tomasz Szmydt asked for political asylum in Belarus.

Also, ardent opponents are more often well aware of the details of the shelling of Belgorod and Kharkiv, as well as of the events during the terrorist attack at Crocus City Hall in Moscow, while other segments note that they know about them in general and without details.

Representatives of the detached segment are generally significantly less likely to claim that they are well aware of these events than other segments.

Thus, pro-democratic speakers are not effective in trying to convince part of the audience and provide it with a point of view about events and phenomena in the country and the world alternative to the pro-government one. Rather, they work exclusively for their already established audience of readers and viewers and mainly influencing their attitudes. This seems to be primarily attributed to a relatively low frequency of publications with a narrative or propaganda function, compared to the frequency of such materials published by the pro-government speakers, as well as to the restricted channels of information dissemination (television is apparently still the main channel of pro-government propaganda). Nevertheless, even on Internet platforms such as Telegram and TikTok, pro-democratic speakers significantly lose to pro–government ones in terms of publication frequency[9]. As a result, the Belarusian pro-government propaganda successfully wins over a neutral audience, establishing the agenda inside the country[10] and building a picture of the world the regime

9 See the Technical Annex 1, Section “Sample of publicaions”

10 According to the agenda-setting theory (M. McCombs, D. Shaw), the media have a significant impact on public opinion directly by the very selection of topics, issues and events that they cover, labelling them as important at the moment. At the same time, ignoring certain facts and events makes them secondary and unimportant in the minds of the audience. In this way, propaganda can manipulate public opinion by reinforcing only the narratives necessary to achieve its goals with selected events, facts and phenomena and ignoring those that may prevent it from the achievement of these goals. For example, pro-government speakers ignore achievements of Belarusian cyber partisans (such as hacking KGB databases or hacking Hrodna Azot computers), probably in order not to contradict the narrative about Lukashenka being a guarantor of security and successful development of the country. As a result, the audience does not recognise these events, except for ardent opponents, who massively consume the content of pro-democratic speakers. More on the topic: Sidorskaya I. Is it important what the media ignore: how the agenda-setting theory works / Media IQ, May 2022.

needs, while the phenomena and events covered by the pro-democratic media get lost against their backdrop.

At the same time, the pro-democratic speakers generally better inform their audience about current events in Belarus and abroad, while the pro-government speakers are more likely to provide information about events selectively (probably for reasons of propaganda and ideology).

7 STATE AND SOCIETY RELATIONS

Repressions remain one of the most important tools in the relations between the state and society. In the reporting period, they were concentrated on destroying the solidarity infrastructure and fighting the Belarusian diaspora. Besides the repressive pressure on society, the regime of Alyaksandr Lukashenka continues to attack Belarusian culture and identity, systematically supporting "the Russian world". Society can resist only in a form of an anonymous partisan movement, and this trend is gradually spreading to the Belarusian diaspora.

Along with hardcore propaganda, virtually total control and infringement of human rights, direct repressions (both in their narrow [1], and broad [2] understanding) continue to be one of the main ways of interaction between the regime of Alyaksandr Lukashenka and Belarusian society. The main trends in the repressive pressure of the authorities on society have developed in recent years and are described in the previous issues of the Belarus Change Tracker [3]. However, two significant trends have intensified in the reporting period.

ATTEMPT TO DESTROY THE SOLIDARITY INFRASTRUCTURE

The first trend is a new, expanded attack on cross–border ties and solidarity of the Belarusian society.

Media communication between diaspora structures and Belarusians in Belarus was one of the first to be criminalised. In order to cut off communication between independent media and Belarusians in Belarus, besides prosecution for subscriptions to media, back in 2022, the authorities initiated first criminal cases for interviews with independent media in exile. Now the repressions have got to those who attended court sessions on political cases and shared information about such trials with the media and human rights organisations[4][5]. At the same time, in order to discredit the diaspora, the authorities are intensifying efforts to create fake accounts of independent media and democratic initiatives, launching provocations on behalf of political structures and solidarity initiatives.

Since 2023, the security forces have been persecuting Belarusians for providing financial assistance (donations) to mutual assistance initiatives. In the reporting period, the authorities, without any legal justification, began to persecute those who provided help not to such initiatives but directly to political prisoners, sending them money transfers or food parcels[6].

The most remarkable trend of 2024 is the criminalisation of assistance from diaspora initiatives. This is an unprecedented practice: the families of political prisoners, as well as former political prisoners who received such assistance, are charged with "association with extremists" (361-1 of the Criminal Code, 361-2 of the Criminal Code, 361-4 of the Criminal Code, etc.) and "using foreign gratuitous assistance to carry out terrorist and other kind of extremist activities or other actions prohibited by law" (24.15 of the Administrative Code).

The attack on cross-border connections is unfolding as the Belarusian authorities create barriers for Belarusians who want to work, study or go on tourist trips outside the territory of Belarus: advertising

[1] Коршунаў, Г. Барометр рэпрэсій у Беларусі. I квартал 2024 года / Центр Новых Идэй, красавік 2024.

[2] Права человека в Беларуси: основные тренды государственной политики / Беларусский Хельсинкский Комитет, 2024

[3] Belarus Change Tracker

[4] Сілавікі паведамілі пра затрыманне трох чалавек за супрацоўніцтва з «Вясною» / Наша Ніва, март 2024

[5] Хрысьціянскага прапаведніка Сяргея Мельянца паўторна арыштавалі на 12 сутак / Радыё Свабода, апрель 2024

[6] Силовики в Беларуси взялись за посылки политзаключенным / DW, апрель 2022

of work outside Belarus is prohibited, language courses are eliminated, scientists have to go through a tougher procedure to get a permission to participate in foreign conferences, school graduates are denied the documents necessary for admission to foreign universities, employees of state organisations are "strongly not recommended" to go on holiday to "unfriendly" countries[7].

Additionally, the regime pays a lot of attention to the employees of state organisations (at least medical and higher education institutions) to collect information about their relatives who live abroad.

DECLARATION OF WAR ON THE DIASPORA

Another trend, closely related to the first one, is the escalation of the regime's confrontation with the Belarusian diaspora. Although we wrote about this earlier, the trend significantly increased in 2024. The repressions in this direction have been intensified as the democratic forces announced the election to the Coordination Council of the third convocation. In response to the announcement of and preparation for this election, the Belarusian regime declared all the voting lists to be extremist formations and began criminal proceedings against 257 participants in the Coordinating Council election. They were charged under four articles of the Criminal Code, including conspiracy to seize state power. Besides trials in absentia, which are not new for the Belarusian regime, these people face confiscation of property in Belarus. The Belarusian authorities did not take such measures so widely before.

The initiation of numerous collective cases against representatives of the Belarusian diaspora is a distinctive feature of the reporting period. In addition to the Coordination Council election case, there are cases of "Personnel Reserve", "People's Embassies", "Belarusians Abroad" and "Tsikhanouskaya's Analysts". The most prominent one is apparently "Case of 104"[8], which was opened against Belarusians who live abroad and, according to the Belarusian security services, took part in Freedom Day celebrations in 2024. This case is special because it is targeting ordinary representatives of the Belarusian diaspora, not activists or politicians, but completely low-profile Belarusians. These people are also facing arrest and confiscation of property. For the first time, the flats of low-profile Belarusians have been put on auction.

This means that repressions against the diaspora are progressing and go further down from the political and organisational level to ordinary low-profile Belarusians. This is confirmed by the increased attention of the Belarusian security forces to the online communities and chats of the diaspora (with the attempts to seize control over them), the intensifying attempts to identify representatives of the diaspora and establish personal contacts with them (for example, those who helped political prisoners, or members of the diaspora chats).

Alyaksandr Lukashenka has made his position on this issue quite clear, addressing Belarusians abroad: "Do not forget that you are hurting your relatives very much. Do not forget that you have some property here; you can forget about this property now. Still, do not put your relatives at risk."[9]. The purpose of such statements is obvious – to pacify the Belarusian diaspora, instil the feelings of fear and helplessness, demotivate and depoliticise Belarusians abroad like it was done inside Belarus.

[7] «А потом там и останетесь». Сотрудников крупной организации просят не ездить в «недружественные» страны — узнали подробности / Зеркало, июнь 2024

[8] Название «дела 104» достаточно условное, по нему может проходить и в два раза больше людей: «Следак говорил, что у него список из 200 человек». Силовики приходят с обысками в квартиры уехавших беларусов / Медиазона.Беларусь, май 2024

[9] Лукашэнка прыгразіў беларусам замежжа рэпрэсіямі супраць сваякоў і пазбаўленьнем маёмасьці / Радыё Свабода, апрель 2024

CONSISTENCY OF "THE RUSSIAN WORLD"

Another important trend in the relations between the state and society is the controlled promotion of "the Russian world". This trend is not new, it has been characteristic of the rule of Alyaksandr Lukashenka since its very beginning. What has changed is the intensity of the processes, their main subjects and objects of the efforts applied.

In the reporting period, this trend was most clearly manifested in the urban environment (although the literature written by Belarusian classics or about Belarusian history is still being recognised as extremist materials). Over the past months of 2024, several monuments have been unveiled in Belarusian cities, all of them dedicated to people clearly connected to "the Russian world": Metropolitan Bishop Joseph (Semashko), Metropolitan Bishop Filaret (Vakhromeyev) and writer Ivan Bunin. At the same time, propagandists repeatedly raise the issue of renaming Kalinouski Street in Minsk.

Besides the erection of monuments, Belarus witnessed another landmark event: the Immortal Regiment campaign was held in Minsk and all regional centres on 9 May. It was the first time when the pro-Russian activists were permitted to organise the event. Earlier, the Belarusian authorities did not welcome independent marches under the auspices of the Immortal Regiment and even invented their own replacement (an apple flower on a red-green ribbon) for the ribbon of Saint George, the Regiment's symbol.

However, the Belarusian regime does not always take cues from pro-Russian activists, rather the opposite. Over the past months of 2024, a series of not-so-subtle hints to "volunteer" agents of "the Russian world" have been made. The activists were in no uncertain terms shown that the promotion of "the Russian world" should be sanctioned and controlled from above. Among such signals is the liquidation of the Belarusian Public Association of Teachers of Russian Language and Literature, which enjoyed the support of the Embassy of the Russian Federation and Rossotrudnichestvo. Also, administrative cases were initiated against activists (Elvira Mirsalimova, Nikolai Petrushenko, Aleksandr Andreikov, etc.) who were advised to slow down their media activities.

TRENDS IN RESISTANCE TO THE REGIME

In terms of the response of the protest part of Belarusian society to the Lukashenka regime, all possibilities tend to indicate only one option – partisan or at least anonymous resistance to the regime. Now, after an abrupt increase in repressions, this trend of depoliticisation or going anonymous is beginning to spread to Belarusians abroad.

A striking example of such resistance is the actions of Cyber Partisans, a group of hacktivists who fight the Belarusian government. Over the past months, this initiative has performed a number of high–profile political actions, from hacking the Hrodna Azot website to infiltrating the KGB information systems. Another example (or a direction accessible even to non–professionals) is raising money both for the benefit of Belarusians in difficult life situations and for Belarusian units fighting as part of the Armed Forces of Ukraine.

However, not all Belarusians abroad are demotivated by a threat of repressions. The Belarusian diaspora continues to organise traditional events dedicated to significant dates (the anniversary of the Russian invasion of Ukraine, Freedom Day, Chernobyl Way) and events in memory of political prisoners in general and those who died in prison in particular.

TECHNICAL ANNEX 1

To study political communication on online platforms, we used an abductive approach: a combination of an inductive approach for recording events and narratives and a deductive approach for determining the goals of communication with the audience. We used content analysis with mixed (qualitative and quantitative) methods. The analysis consisted of four stages.

To analyse political communication on online platforms, the Belarus Change Tracker team orders opinion surveys from two data providers. Data from the main provider are used to prepare the section "Trends in Public Opinion." The secondary provider's results are analysed to check whether the trends visible in the main provider's data are reproduced and verified by the secondary data. This primarily applies to analysing segments of social conflict.

During the first stage, we recorded all the messages that appeared in the analysed materials. At this stage, we got more than 350 messages. During the second stage, we studied all the publications in the selected Telegram channels and TikTok accounts, recording the publications that mentioned Belarus-related events. During the third stage, based on the previous research[1], we registered the communication tactics pursued by the pro-government and pro-democratic content creators in their communication with the audience in all event-related publications: legitimation, discrediting, manipulation, ideologisation.

After filling out an analytical table with the analysis of each publication by the specified parameters, we carried out statistical processing of the results in order to understand which messages are common in the pro-democratic and pro-government segments in Telegram and TikTok, what goals the speakers pursue when communicating with the audience and what events became the most important during the analysis period. During the last stage of the analysis, we grouped previously obtained messages into larger narratives.

CONTENT FORMAT IN TELEGRAM AND TIKTOK

The nature of content in Telegram and TikTok is different. Since TikTok content creators are mainly individual users, the coverage of events and articulation of ideas does not give the impression of top-down produced content. Also, the structure of the platform and the entertaining format of the content, which frequently features music, cartoon sketches, memes and funny images, determines the superficiality of the messages in the videos. A feature of TikTok is that videos or accounts are frequently deleted, which we already observed during the previous studies[2]. Therefore, we analysed the channels in live time, collecting videos for sampling once a week. For the same reason, the period covers three weeks (1-22 May) when the research team was conducting the analysis. Trying to cover videos published in March or April would have skewed the results because of the short life cycle of many TikTok videos.

Unlike on TikTok, Telegram publications are more consistent. On the one hand, this may be attributed to the fact that a lot of content there is rather professional than amateur. The authors of Telegram channels are often bloggers, journalists, state media speakers, representatives of pro-

[1] von Soest, Christian, and Grauvogel, Julia 2017. "Identity, procedures and performance: How authoritarian regimes legitimize their rule." Contemporary Politics 23, no. 3: 287–305

Gerschewski, Johannes. 2018. "Legitimacy in autocracies: Oxymoron or essential feature?" Perspectives on Politics. Cambridge University Press 16, no. 3: 652–665

Feldstein, Steven. 2021. The rise of digital repression: How technology is reshaping power, politics, and resistance. Oxford: Oxford University Press.

[2] Rudnik, A. (2023). Digital transformation trends in belarusian democratic resistance: Narratives, Perceptions, and Reaction of the State / FES, октябрь 2023

democratic forces or state institutions. This may explain why the choice of events to cover and the promoted narratives are more interconnected, which has already been observed in other studies[3]. Also, the structure of the platform does not provide such extensive opportunities for entertaining content as TikTok. The life cycle of publications in Telegram is longer, making it possible for us to cover the period of March-May 2024 without skewing the results of the study.

CHANNEL SELECTION

The choice of channels and accounts is based on quality in order to ensure the highest variability. On the one hand, the sample included the major news channels with the largest number of subscribers. On the other hand, it included channels of politicians, political structures and state institutions. The sample also contained channels that analyse the socio-political situation in Belarus, as well as channels and accounts of journalists. We sorted channels by relevance via TGStat.com where you can sort them by topic, number of subscribers or mutual channel recommendations.

We searched for both pro-democratic and pro-government TikTok channels in the same way: searching for relevant TikTok accounts of the media, politicians or propagandists from already established Telegram channels. We expanded the network of accounts by searching for subscriptions, comments to videos or hashtags. Also, pro-government TikTok accounts often use similar audio, for example, from Lukashenka's speeches, which helped us find additional accounts.

LIST OF ANALYSED TIKTOK ACCOUNTS AND TELEGRAM CHANNELS

TikTok (1-22 May)		Telegram (1 March – 22 May)	
Pro-government	**Pro-democratic**	**Pro-government**	**Pro-democratic**
adikadikovski	365bel	Азарёнок. СТВ. Беларусь	BELPOL
alexeipinchuk2004	a_ivulin	БЕЛАРУСКАЯ КУХНЯ	NEXTA
art1kys1	baba_gala_rulit	Белорусский силовик BY	PM
bel.pravda	belamova	Гайдукевич Олег	Usov Pavel
belarusseychas	belamova2.0	Главный. Тур	Аб’яднаны Пераходны Кабінет
brsm_life	belarusnovosti	ЖС Premium	Беларусь головного мозга
chupa_stepa	chaly_night	Земля наша	Валерий Цепкало
evgenbelorus	godofbelarus	Инфокиоск «Боген и Ко»	Дмитрий Болкунец
first_news_	knyrovich.business	КрысолOFF	Ігар Тышкевіч
glory8_88	li_vetrava	Люстэрка ўлады	Каардынацыйная Рада
govorit__gomel	margarita.levchuk	Людмила Гладкая. СБ	Лукабек
gruzdevy	nau_belarus	МВД Беларуси	Мая Краіна Беларусь
ldpb_pravda	nikolai_tiko	Невольфович	МотолькоПомоги
med2vedtata8	nil_la	Партия «Белая Русь»	Ник и Майк

[3] Как менялись нарративы белорусской пропаганды в 2022 году / MediaIQ, ноябрь 2022

newsinbelarus	pavel_latushka	Пул Первого	Павел Латушка
novostibelorusa	pravicebsk	РОО «БЕЛАЯ РУСЬ»	Письма к дочери
police_grodno	prezident.sveta	Совет Республики Национального собрания Республики Беларусь	Полк Каліноўскага
prosropervy	Pulpervogo (Неруссо туристо)	Художник Светлана Жигимонт	Светлана Тихановская
saciolog	serca_u_belarusi	Шпаковский	Чай з малінавым варэннем
swetka.takaja	strana888	Это другое	
system_pravo	tarot_belarus	Я/МЫ ОМОН	
uggla2001	thisminsk		
voenkom.pro	traianus_n		
zabelarusz	witzmag		

SAMPLE OF PUBLICATIONS

During the period of 1-22 May, 1,159 videos were published in 48 selected TikTok channels, 724 by the pro-government speakers and 435 by the pro-democratic ones. Having watched all the videos, we selected those with a narrative charge (34%) and excluded entertaining videos. Using the methodology described above, we analysed 393 videos.

TikTok

		Pro-government	Pro-democratic
Number of videos in the selected channels	1 159	724	435
		62.5%	37.5%
Sample (videos with a narrative load)	393	237	156
		60.3%	39.7%

In the period of 1 March – 22 May, 33,605 publications were published in 40 selected Telegram channels. Since the authors of Telegram channels are highly active, we reduced the volume of the materials for analysis by using a random sample of publications. In the channels with less than 100 published posts, we analysed each of them. In the channels with a large number of publications, we randomly selected 100-200 posts per each month. Only text materials from the Telegram publications were analysed.

Telegram

		Pro-government	Pro-democratic
Number of videos in the selected channels	33 607	26 518	7 089
		78.91%	21.09%
Sample	3 770	2 442	1 328
		65%	35%
	March	898	500

		64%	36%
	April	842	396
		68%	32%
	May	702	432
		62%	38%

TECHNICAL ANNEX 2

To analyse dynamics in public opinion, the Belarus Change Tracker team orders opinion surveys from online panel providers. They are services where Belarusians register to take part in surveys. Recruiting is done via a snowball effect, as well as via online advertising in such services as Google, Yandex, OK, VK (VKontakte), Facebook, etc. The online panel gathers 70,000–100,000 participants. These people receive invitations to participate in various surveys. Each month approximately 750 new participants are recruited, most of whom cease to be active panellists within six months (only about 15% remain active).

In several previous waves of research, quota sampling was used to collect data. Then, the sample structure corresponded to the internet-connected urban population of Belarus by gender, age, settlement size and education.

From Issue 4 onwards, the BCT team stopped using quotas and is now using simple random sampling aimed at reflecting the structure of the online panel. Providers send out 25,000 invitations to users and keep the survey open for seven days. We re-weigh the collected data to make their structure precisely reflect the structure of the online panel by gender, age, settlement size and education (Table A2.2). The resulting sample is not representative of the population of Belarus, but it is representative of the structure of the online panel.

When using this data collection procedure, the BCT team is guided by the following logic:

- Significant changes in Belarusian public opinion will surely be reflected in the selection of 70,000–100,000 panellists. Thus, a random selection of a sample of about 1,000 respondents (Table A2.1), representative of the panel should also reflect these changes.
- This data collection method allows us speculating about trends and phenomena within the segments of society under study. The survey mathematically divides society into four clusters. Inside each of them, the respondents have fairly clear characteristics. We have no reason to assume that the characteristics of these segments in the online panel that we represent significantly differ from the views of these same segments in Belarusian wider society. This is confirmed, among other things, by the fact that other public opinion studies [1], based on samples corresponding to the entire urban population show the same segments as our study. Therefore, based on the data of the Belarus Change Tracker, we can make conclusions about the distribution of opinions within the segments of the Belarusian society.

When preparing all the reports from Issue 4 onwards, the data of the first three survey waves have been re-weighted by the structure of the online panel and used for dynamics analysis. Thus, there is a possibility that the dynamics observed between the first three and all subsequent issues may derive from the change in the approach to the sample.

While considering our data reliable and valid, we emphasise that the results of public opinion polling in Belarus require a special interpretation approach. The Belarusian government systematically persecutes the expression of certain opinions, which results in increased anxiety of respondents when answering some of the questions in the questionnaire. Therefore, the shares of response options related to criticism of the government are probably underestimated: respondents choose more neutral options instead of expressing what they really think[2].

Some respondents also drop out of the survey due to sensitive questions. In the current wave, 13% of those who started taking the survey dropped out on the block of political questions, which was at the

[1] Биканов Ф., Нестерович К. Беларусская национальная идентичность в 2023 году / Friedrich Ebert Stiftung, декабрь 2023 – Стр. 34-37

[2] Belarusians' views on the war and the impact of the fear factor on online public opinion polling / Center for New Ideas, Chatham House, December 2023.

very beginning, immediately after the socio-demographic questions. As a result, some of the more neutral and critical opinions towards the government may be underrepresented[3] in the final distributions.

The nature of online surveys makes them reflect the opinion of the more economically and socially active urban population. Therefore, the distributions in the sample may show a higher level of politicisation and awareness of the socio-political situation than the actual one in society.

Table A2.1. Technical indicators of data collection

	Number of people	Percentage
A1. Invitations sent out	2500	
A2. Those who started to fill out the questionnaire	1191	
A3. Those who did not pass the screening section of the questionnaire	81	
A4. Those who dropped out of the survey after the screening section	268	
A5. Those who completed the survey	842	
Response rate (A2/A1)		5%
Dropout rate (A4/(A2-A3))		24%

Data collection period for the current wave: 28 May - 1 June 2024.

Below is s a comparison of the structures in the achieved sample, the invitations sent out, the main online panel and the urban population of Belarus with Internet access (Table A2.2).

Table A2.2. Socio-demographic structure

	Invitations sent out	Those who completed the survey	In the panel structure (target for weighing)	In the structure of urban residents with Internet access
Age group				
18–24	29%	7%	11%	10%
25–34	35%	21%	26%	22%
35–44	23%	25%	29%	22%
45+	12%	47%	33%	45%
Gender				
Male	54%	54%	31%	44%
Female	46%	46%	69%	56%
Region				
Brest oblast	13%	12%	14%	12%
Vitebsk oblast	12%	10%	12%	12%
Gomel oblast	15%	18%	15%	14%
Hrodna oblast	11%	10%	11%	10%

[3] (Не)честные ответы в опросах: страх, прагматизм и искренняя нейтральность / belaruspolls.org, апрель 2024

	Invitations sent out	Those who completed the survey	In the panel structure (target for weighing)	In the structure of urban residents with Internet access
Minsk oblast	15%	12%	15%	10%
Mogilev oblast	12%	12%	11%	11%
Minsk city	22%	26%	22%	31%

We have also made the data sets used in the study freely accessible:

- in dynamics (.sav; .xlsx);
- in statics (.sav; .xlsx).

SEGMENTS OF SOCIAL CONFLICT

The Social Conflict Segmentation (SCS) is based on the assessment of people's confidence in both state and non-state institutions, as well as in supporters and opponents of government. During data collection, respondents are asked to rate how much they trust or distrust certain groups, for example "the police" or "people designated as political prisoners". The analysis of these assessments allows us to divide Belarusian society into four groups according to their degree of trust or distrust in the authorities: **ardent supporters**, **moderate supporters**, **moderate opponents** and **ardent opponents**. A fair part of society comprises **moderate** and **ardent opponents** and they tend not to trust the government structures. The other part is formed of **moderate** and **ardent supporters**. Both segments vary significantly in socio-demographic characteristics: the group of ardent opponents is dominated by men and people with higher levels of education, and representatives of this segment are more likely to live in Minsk and have higher incomes. By contrast, there are more women among **ardent supporters**. **Ardent supporters** are generally less well-educated and have below average incomes. **Ardent** and **moderate supporters** demonstrate high confidence in pro-governmental institutions and those social groups that were singled out through factor analysis as "supportive of the authorities".

Below is a list of institutions, people or groups of people that we asked the respondents to rate on a scale of "fully distrust — rather distrust — rather trust — fully trust".

- Armed Forces;
- Police;
- Investigative Committee;
- Prosecutor's Office;
- State Security Committee;
- State media;
- Non-state media;
- Government;
- Officials;
- Citizens of Belarus who emigrated in fear of prosecution at home;
- Participants in protests on the summer and autumn of 2020;
- People who do not trust the authorities;
- People who trust the authorities;

- Supporters of the current government;
- People who reject the results of the 2020 presidential election;
- People who recognise the results of the 2020 presidential election;
- People labelled political prisoners.

NARRATIVE ASSIMILATION INDEX

The narrative assimilation index represents the difference between those who to some extent agreed with a statement and those who disagreed with a statement. Thus, the index can range from **-100 to +100:**

- If the index value is in the range from -100 to -20, the narrative is unequivocally rejected by the audience;
- If the index is in the range from -19 to +19, we assume that the audience has not yet formed an attitude towards this statement;
- If the index is in the range from +20 to +100, it means that the narrative has been fully assimilated and accepted by the audience.

SEGMENTS BY COMMITMENT TO NARRATIVES

The segments by commitment to narratives are based on the extent of agreement of the respondents with the statements based on the narratives spread in the spring of 2024 among the pro-government and pro-democratic speakers.

Below is a list of statements the respondents were asked to agree or disagree with on a scale of: 1. Fully agree 2. Rather agree 3. Difficult to answer 4. Rather disagree 5. Fully disagree

- Belarus is preparing to join the war on the Russia's side;
- They want to drag Belarus into a war;
- It will be better if Lukashenka stays in power as long as possible;
- Belarus is a true democracy, unlike the West;
- Mass persecution for a political position is taking place in Belarus;
- There is a split in the Belarusian opposition (among opponents of the current government);
- In the near future, flows of refugees from Western countries fleeing political persecution can be expected in Belarus;
- If Belarus is attacked, the Belarusian and Russian armies will be able to defend the country;
- The conditions in the Russian army are in general better than in the Ukrainian one;
- Lukashenka's power is completely dependent on support from the Kremlin;
- European elites are puppets of the US;
- The West no longer wants to support the Belarusian opposition (opponents of the current government);
- Current Western elites basically support the Nazi ideology;
- Lukashenka is the most corrupt official;

- Lukashenka is doing everything to prevent Belarus from being dragged into the war;
- Lukashenka forces officials to work for the benefit of people;
- Lukashenka is not an independent politician, he receives instructions from the Kremlin;
- Lukashenka is rebuilding the system of power in the Republic of Belarus for his resignation;
- Lukashenka is successfully fighting corruption in Belarus;
- It is necessary to protect Belarusian youth from the influence of Western values;
- Government officials responsible for violence against Belarusians should be punished;
- Russia is a threat to the sovereignty of Belarus;
- Moral decay, non-existent in Belarus, prevails in the West;
- It will soon become obvious to everyone that the Belarusian economy is falling apart;
- The United States is the main warmonger in the world, pursuing its own interests;
- Those who oppose Lukashenka are traitors who must be punished.

THE EVENTS OF SPRING 2024 MENTIONED IN THE SURVEY

The following is a list of events. Respondents were asked to answer whether this event took place this spring or not. Based on these answers, we estimated the visibility of the events in Belarusian society:

- Lukashenka's visit to Azerbaijan;
- Snap inspection of non-strategic nuclear weapons carriers jointly with Russia;
- Snap inspection of the air defence forces in Belarus;
- Lukashenka's meeting with the representatives of the Magadan oblast of the Russian Federation;
- Changes in legislation for individual entrepreneurs;
- Large-scale celebration of the Day of the National Flag, Emblem and Anthem;
- Violent murder of a young Belarusian woman in the centre of Warsaw;
- Shelling of Belgorod and the Belgorod oblast;
- Shelling of Kharkiv and the Kharkiv oblast;
- The assassination attempt on Robert Fico;
- Maryna Vasileuskaya's flight into space;
- Polish judge Tomasz Szmydt has asked for political asylum in Belarus;
- Victory Day celebrations in Belarus;
- Adoption of the new military doctrine and the concept of national security of Belarus;
- Protests against the "foreign agent" law in Georgia;
- Congress of the renewed All-Belarusian People's Assembly (ABPA);
- Attack at Crocus City Hall in Moscow;
- Hacker attack on the computers at the Hrodna Azot plant;
- Hackers have published databases of Belarusians' appeals to the KGB.

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